

CM reviews energy-saving steps in online meeting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In an effort to reduce fuel consumption, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday held meetings with her officials in the virtual mode and held a detailed review meeting. She directed them to implement the measures announced on Thursday effectively.

The important administrative meetings were attended by Divisional Commissioner, all District Magistrates (DMs) and senior officials of various departments.

The Chief Minister asked officials to conduct maximum Government meetings through online platforms so that fuel, time and resources could be saved. She directed all departments to take effective measures to reduce electricity consumption, adopt



energy-saving practices in offices and develop a responsible administrative work culture.

Rekha Gupta directed all departments to ensure at least a 20 per cent reduction in fuel expenses on official vehicles. Stressing the need to prioritise the 'Metro Monday' initiative, she said officers and employees should use the Metro and

public transport at least one day a week so that a positive message reaches the public. Along with this, directions were also issued to effectively implement 'No Vehicle Day' once a week.

During the meeting, Rekha Gupta also instructed officials to carry out continuous inspections in their respective areas. The Chief Minister said common citizens should

receive the benefits of Government facilities in a timely and organised manner.

Reviewing preparations for the monsoon, the Chief Minister directed officials to identify waterlogging-prone areas and take necessary action in time. She said no drains should remain open in any area and dangerous trees should be removed immediately so that people do not face difficulties during the rainy season. Officials were also instructed to speed up work related to PNG connections in their areas.

The CM said all officials should regularly share information related to works being carried out and corrective measures taken in their respective areas through social media, so that people receive transparent information about Government functioning.

Bus gang rape case began over payment dispute, police claim

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

In the alleged rape case of a woman inside a bus, Delhi police officials claimed that the incident began with a dispute over payment for sexual services. According to Police, the accused allegedly refused to pay the full agreed-upon amount after the services were provided.

According to Delhi Police, the woman alleged that a bus driver and his helper gang raped her inside a private bus after she boarded it near Saraswati Vihar while returning home from work on 12 May. Following her complaint, police arrested the two accused, identified as Umesh and Ramendra, and seized the bus for forensic examination. Ramendra was allegedly driving the vehicle at the time.

Police officials told *The Pioneer* that during their



investigation, they claimed the woman had boarded the bus after agreeing to provide sexual services to the accused in exchange for money. Officials stated a dispute about the payment arose after one of the accused allegedly paid only part of the agreed amount, which they claim escalated before the alleged assault. Officials further claimed that soon after the incident, the woman made a PCR call using the cell phone of one of the accused.

The incident allegedly took

place in the early hours of 12 May. The police said the accused are both residents of Uttar Pradesh and were present in the city at the time.

In her complaint, the woman alleged that on the night of 12 May, she reached the bus stand in Saraswati Vihar and asked a man standing by the private bus's door for the time. She alleged that the man pulled her into the vehicle, after which the bus began moving towards Nangloi. The driver and conductor then allegedly raped her one after the other.

The woman, who is married and has three children, underwent a medical examination on the same day following the incident.

An FIR was registered at Rani Bagh police station under relevant BNS sections, including rape, gang rape, and common intention. Police said the case is under investigation.

Delhi pushes major deregulation drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday reviewed the progress of the Capital's deregulation exercise aimed at improving ease of doing business and ease of living, while directing officials to complete all pending priority reforms identified by the Centre before June 30, 2026.

Chairing a high-level meeting with senior Delhi Government officials, the Lieutenant Governor said the administration was working to create a governance system in which businesses and citizens face fewer regulatory hurdles and faster approvals.

Sandhu said Delhi had improved its position in the 2025 LEADS rankings among Union Territories, moving from the "Achievers" category to the higher "Exemplar" category. The LEADS ranking, prepared by the Government of India, evaluates States and Union Territories on logistics performance, business reforms, and infrastructure development.

The Lieutenant Governor said the Government's focus was now on creating a "Permitted Until Prohibited" framework by reducing outdated regulations and simpli-



fying governance structures. Officials familiar with the discussions said the administration is trying to shift from excessive controls towards a system that allows smoother functioning for businesses unless specific restrictions are required.

During the meeting, Sandhu reviewed the progress of the proposed Omnibus Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026, which is being prepared to simplify approvals and reduce compliance requirements across departments. Officials said the proposed legislation is expected to streamline several administrative procedures and make interactions between businesses and Government departments more transparent and time-efficient.

CAQM tightens anti-pollution measures in Delhi-NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) has approved a series of major anti-pollution measures for Delhi-NCR, including a phased shift to electric three-wheelers, restrictions on fuel supply to vehicles without valid pollution certificates and stricter action against stubble burning in neighbouring States.

The Commission also approved Draft Direction No 101, which proposes that fuel stations across NCR will supply fuel only to vehicles carrying valid Pollution Under Control Certificates (PUC) from October 1, 2026.

The decisions were taken during the 28th full commission meeting held virtually on May 15 under the chairmanship of CAQM Chairperson



Rajesh Verma. Senior officials reviewed multiple issues linked to air pollution control across the NCR.

One of the key decisions taken during the meeting was the approval of Draft Direction No 100, which mandates registration of only electric three-wheelers of the L5 category in Delhi-NCR in a phased manner.

Under the plan, only electric passenger and goods three-wheelers of the L5 cat-

egory will be allowed to be registered in Delhi from January 1, 2027. The rule will come into force from January 1, 2028, in high vehicle density districts adjoining Delhi, including Gurugram, Faridabad, Sonapat, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddha Nagar. The remaining NCR districts will implement the rule from January 1, 2029.

The Commission said the decision was taken after experts identified vehicular emissions as one of the major contributors to PM2.5 pollution levels in Delhi-NCR. Officials said an expert committee constituted by the CAQM in December 2025 had also recommended a faster transition towards electric three-wheelers. On the issue of mandatory PUC for fuel, the Commission said the step is aimed at reducing harmful vehicular emissions, including PM2.5, nitrogen oxides and carbon monoxide, which continue to affect air quality in the region. During the meeting, officials expressed concern over a sharp rise in wheat stubble burning incidents this year. According to CAQM data, Punjab reported 8,986 incidents between April 1 and May 14 this year compared to 6,474 cases during the same period in 2025.

Amity Noida's Sanjana Chauhan tops financial markets management

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With celebrations across schools and homes following the declaration of the CBSE Class 12 board examination results, a student from Amity International School, Noida emerged as the only candidate in the Delhi-NCR region to secure a perfect 100 out of 100 in Financial Markets Management.

Sanjana Chauhan, a Class 12 student of the school, achieved the feat in the subject, which continues to see limited enrollment among students.



Speaking about her choice of subject, Sanjana said her teachers played a key role in guiding her towards Financial Markets Management. "Having studied for so many years at Amity International School, Noida, my teachers know my interests and strengths. My teachers suggested I try the subject and once I reviewed the course, I instantly knew I had to pursue it," she said.

Crediting her preparation strategy and school environment for the achievement, the student said she learnt the importance of discipline and planning through competitions and extracurricular activities organised by the school. "From the beginning of my 12th grade, I prepared weekly timetables for my academics which later became daily timetables. That helped me complete my syllabus," she said.

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

E-AUCTION NOTICE

No. CLW/Dankuni/Scrap/680 Dated : 12.05.2026

The following M&P items will be appeared in e-auction on 20.05.26, 28.05.26 in May month.

SL. No.	LOT NO.	Description	Quantity	LOCATION
1.	RED009072025	Scrap Component Fixture FOT Diesel Loco WDP & WDG Type Loco, Asset No. MW/FS/06.	01 No.	Under frame shop
2.	RED010072025	Scrap Component Fixture FOT Diesel Loco WDP & WDG Type Loco, Asset No. MW/FS/05.	01 No.	Under frame shop
3.	RED013072025	Scrap Fixture FOT Diesel Loco WDP & WDG Type Underframe Trunion-II, Asset No. MW/UF/02.	01 No.	Under frame shop
4.	RED020092025	Scrap Conventional Travelling Column Radial Drilling Machine, Asset No. MW/BS/04, MARKED C.	01 No.	Column No. A-19/BS
5.	RED022092025	Scrap CNC Two Way Angular Boring Machine, Asset No. MW/BS/03, MARKED E.	01 No.	Column No. A-22/BS
6.	RED023092025	Scrap Washer High Pressure Station (Crank Case) Engine Block Washer, Accessories 1/3 to 3/3, Asset No. MW/BS/02. MARKED F.	01 No.	Column No. A-27/BS
7.	RED024092025	Scrap Coordinate Measuring Machine, Excluding Enclosure, Accessories 1/18 to 18/18, Asset No. MW/BS/01, MARKED G.	01 No.	Column No. A-30/BS
8.	RED027102025	Scrap Fixture for Diesel Loco WDP & WDG Type Underframe Lay Down-I (Including Strong Back for Laydown-I) Asset No. MW/UF/09.	01 No.	Under frame shop
9.	RED034122025	Scrap Underframe Paint Booth, Excluding Railway Tracks, Asset No. MW/UF/01, MARKED K.	01 No.	Under frame shop
10.	RED037122025	Scrap Electric Operated Traverser along with DSL, Capacity 50 MT, excluding Metallic Structure through which the DSL Passes and railway Tracks also, Asset No. MTS/TRAVERSER/50T. MARKED Q.	01 No.	Infront of Admin building

It is noticed that all above 10 Nos. Lots are showing in auction catalogue in GeM-IREPS. E-Auction Sale website <https://www.ireps.gov.in> of ELAAU/DANKUNI-STORES/CLW Depot/Railway unit. All the interested purchasers may please visit the respective Lot physically prior to auction date. All the terms & conditions are as per e-auction catalogue and uniform sale conditions for e-auction.

PR6/350 Dy. CMM/Depot/Dankuni

Visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

For and on behalf of President of India, Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Cord.), Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites open e-tender on 'SINGLE PACKET SYSTEM' for following work from experienced and capable tenders.

1. Name of work	Dismantling, fitment of EPPFS at new location, assembly of components including pneumatic and electric connections, Repairing/Overhauling and testing of Electro Pneumatic Pressurised flushing system of LHB coaches of Delhi Division.
2. Work Place	Delhi
3. Period of Work	Twelve (12) Months
4. Advertised Value	Rs. 32,74,808.00/- (including provision of GST)
5. Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 65,500.00/-, through net banking or gateway only
6. Tender Document Cost	Nil
7. Date and Time availability of E-Tender Document	From 13.05.2026 to 04.06.2026 at 12:00 hrs
8. Date and time of E-tender Closing	04.06.2026, 12:00 hrs
9. Date and time of E-tender opening	On 13.05.2026 after 16:43 hrs, if the date of opening happens to be holiday then E-Tender shall be opened on the next working day.
10. Place for opening E-Tender	Mechanical Department, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi-55

Note: The complete particulars of the tender may be found in website www.ireps.gov.in

No.: NRDL0MCNW792025RT Date: 14.05.2026 1628/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Kapil Dev is the GPA holder of Property Bearing No. 116, area measuring 45 Sq. Yds., out of total area measuring 200 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 424, situated in the revenue Estate of Village Haxtal, and the colony known as Mohan Garden, R-Extension, Utam Nagar, New Delhi. He is in possession through Notarized GPA, ATS & Will dated 28.02.2024 executed by Mr. Rajni Yadav in favour of Mr. Kapil Dev in respect of the area measuring 45 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 424. Mr. Kapil Dev intends to transfer the ownership of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Arbaz Khan and Mrs. Kheerun Nisha. Subsequently Mr. Arbaz Khan and Mrs. Kheerun Nisha are in the process of mortgaging the said property with SBFGL India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Vertices (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@vertices.in

Public Notice
Notice is hereby given that my client, Pradeep Kumar Singh, is the absolute owner of the front portion of Property bearing No. 648/725-B, measuring 18.39 sq. meters, i.e., approximately 22 sq. yards, situated at Mohalla Nagar Nigrah, Ghazabad, Tehsil and District Ghazabad, Uttar Pradesh, having inherited the same after the demise of his mother, namely Late Mitlesh Kumar. That Late Mitlesh Kumar had acquired the said property by virtue of a registered Sale Deed dated 04.11.2011, Doc No. 11093, duly executed by Krishna Kumar and Sanjeev Kumar. That my client is now availing a credit facility from HDFC Bank Ltd against the said property in the name and style of 'Mukul Lal Pradeep Kumar (Proprietorship firm)'. All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage, equitable/registered or otherwise, gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise whatsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 07 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
Kamal Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vashi, Gg, U.P. Mob. 9810853551

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all, MERAG BANO W/O. ALI KAZIM KHAN Owner of R/O FLAT NO-89-B, FIRST FLOOR, GULABI BAGH, DELHI-110007. The original document i.e. POSSESSION LETTER AND NO. OF ELECTRICITY AND WATER IN RESPECT OF FREE HOLD has been lost. WIDE FILE NO F-74 (23) /JSG/G. An F.I.R./NCR/LR No.305162/2026 dt.15/05/2026 to this effect has been lodged in P.S.Crime Branch Delhi Any person(s) claiming any right, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write contact with above named person at above Address/Phone 9717544896 within 15days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property, can personally inform or write to: Deputy Director (Housing) UG/G, Development Authority (Saudan), New Delhi-110023.

Public Notice
It is hereby informed that residential house bearing No. A-74, Sector-14, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, originally owned by Late Mr. Vimal Chandra Gupta, is proposed to be mutated/transferred in the name of Mrs. Radhika Gupta, wife of Mr. Manish Gupta, on the basis of a registered Will dated 10.12.2024. If any person/institution has any objection, claim, right, title, ownership, or interest in respect of the aforesaid property, they may submit their objection/claim in writing to the undersigned within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.
Radhika Gupta
9717173509

Ashnoor Textile Mills Ltd.
Regd. Office: Beharampur Road, Village Khandasa, District Gurugram, Haryana-122001
E-mail: delhi@yahoo.com
Phone: 91 0124 4809755
CIN: L17226HR1984PLC033384
NOTICE
NOTICE is hereby given, pursuant to Regulation 29 read with Regulation 47 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, that a meeting of the Board of Directors of the Company will be held on Monday, May 25, 2026, inter-alia, to consider and approve Audited Financial Results of the company for the financial year and 4th Quarter ended March 31, 2026.
This information is also available on Company's website at www.ashnoortext.com and also on the website of BSE, i.e. www.bseindia.com.
By the order of Board
Sd/-
Suneel Gupta
Managing Director
DIN-00052084
March 15, 2026
Gurugram, Haryana

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

81-SRDEE-G-DLI-2026-27 Electrical work in connection with "Replacement of Old aged 03 Nos. V.T. Pumps of 150 HP with other associated accessories at New Rainey Well at HN2M near Akshardham"

Name of Work and its location	81-SRDEE-G-DLI-2026-27 Electrical work in connection with "Replacement of Old aged 03 Nos. V.T. Pumps of 150 HP with other associated accessories at New Rainey Well at HN2M near Akshardham"
Approx. cost of the works in	₹ 9933103.00/-
Address of the Office	Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, DRM Office, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi - 110055
Earnest Money	Rs. 198700.00/-
Last Date & time of submission of tender	05.06.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender	05.06.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board	www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi-1618/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS)

ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-03

No. CE/Comnn/08/2025-26/19

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D (Roads), Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites fresh bid from approved and eligible contractors registered with Assam PWD (Roads) for 1(One) nos. of project amounting to Rs. 1863.2747 Lakh (approx.) for Construction/Upgradation of Road under SOPD-G for the year of 2025-26 pertaining to Sivasagar district (Demow LAC) of Assam.

Details along with Schemes for the works may be seen at website.www.assamtenders.gov.in and also at the office of the undersigned in the "Communication branch". Amendment / Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor / bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Note: NIT Value is inclusive of GST (18%), Labour Cess (1%) etc.

Chief Engineer, PWD (Roads), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/50/16-May-26

BEFORE THE HON'BLE DISTRICT CONSUMER DISPUTES REDRESSAL COMMISSION, THANE

CONSUMER CASE NO. CC/497/CC/335/2025

MR. AMITABH N. NANDI

VERSUS ...COMPLAINANT

KLB KOMAKI PRIVATE LIMITED

OPPOSITE PARTY

PUBLIC NOTICE

Whereas the above matter is pending before this Hon'ble Commission and notice issued to the Opposite Party could not be served at the available address on record. Hence, this public notice is hereby issued informing the Opposite Party to remain present before this Hon'ble Commission on 16/06/2026 at 10:30 a.m. either personally or through its Advocate/authorized representative and file Written Statement/reply in the above matter, failing which ex-parte order shall be passed in accordance with law. By order Hon'ble District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, Thane. Manager District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, Thane

Place: Thane

Date: 20/03/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Rohit Gautam & Mrs. Anika Khurana (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagees/Borrowers), are purchasing Flat No. M-061, 6th Floor, Tower-M, Gulshan Ikabana, Plot No. GH-03A, Sector-143, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, UP-201301 (hereinafter referred to as the said property) from Mrs. Roshan Ara, who became the owner of the said property vide 'Sub Lease Deed 09.08.2016 bearing Document No. 6704, Book No. I, Vol. No. 8551, Page No. 1 to 48, on 20.08.2016 read with Family Membership Certificate dated 28.01.2025 (Patna Sudder & Mutation Letter dated 10.03.2026 issued by Noida Authority. The Borrower will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Axis Bank Ltd., First Floor, Himalaya House, K.G. Marg, New Delhi-110001. Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary disposition or otherwise or having in their custody any title documents pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 15 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 15 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client. Adv. Simran Bajaj 100, 1st Floor, Okhla Phase-III, New Delhi-110020 Phone: +91 148774545/99

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER:: PWD BUILDING:: ASSAM:: GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/06

PRESS NOTICE

It is for general information to all concerned that the bid invited earlier vide Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/04 Dated 13-03-2026 is hereby cancelled and fresh Bid is invited by the Chief Engineer, P.W.D.(Building), Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having requisite experience in similar nature of works for the following work through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I of contract. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Sl No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work (In Rs)	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee	Completion period
1.	Infrastructure Development near Bhoobhath Kali Mandir (Phase-II).	Rs. 8,40,37,949.00	For General category, Rs. 16,80,759.00 and For Reserved category Rs.8,40,379.00	Rs. 16,810.00	18 (Eighteen) Months

Note :-
(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents.
(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Building) Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/49/16-May-26

Audit report flags financial irregularities in DMC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate of Audit has flagged financial and administrative irregularities in the Delhi Medical Council (DMC) between 2019 and 2025.

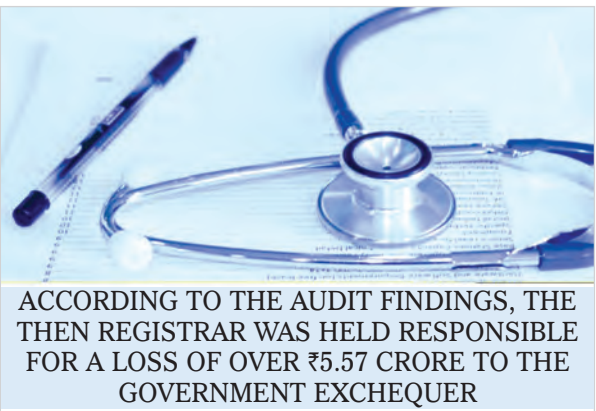
According to the audit findings, the then registrar was held responsible for a loss of over ₹5.57 crore to the Government exchequer due to the collection of reduced fees from doctors for DMC registration renewal. The report also recommended the recovery of over ₹3.23 crore received as salary, allowances and related expenses.

In a statement, the Delhi Government's Health and Family Welfare Department said that it has received a special audit report in the

functioning of the Delhi Medical Council (DMC) between 2019 and 2025.

The Special Audit was conducted to examine violations of DMC Rules, provisions of the DMC Act, 1997 and General Financial Rules (GFR), and to assess the extent of financial irregularities and consequent recovery of unlawfully gained monetary benefits by former office bearers of the Delhi Medical Council. During the audit, records relating to meetings of the Governing Council, Executive Committee and Finance Committee, along with personal files, service books and expenditure records, were scrutinised.

The audit also examined payments related to salary and allowances, pay fixation,



ACCORDING TO THE AUDIT FINDINGS, THE THEN REGISTRAR WAS HELD RESPONSIBLE FOR A LOSS OF OVER ₹5.57 CRORE TO THE GOVERNMENT EXCHEQUER

leave encashment, medical expenses, court fees, foreign visits, hiring of vehicles, telephone expenses and other administrative expenditures.

"The audit pointed to alleged irregularities in extension of service beyond the

retirement age, spending without required approvals, lapses in following financial rules, irregular payments and poor maintenance of official records," the statement said.

The report said the retirement age of the then regis-

trar was increased from 60 years to 65 years allegedly in violation of orders issued by the Centre and the Delhi government from time to time. It also highlighted expenditure on salary and allowances, vehicle hiring, medical reimbursements, telephone expenses, participation in conferences and other administrative expenses during the period under review.

The report has also observed that the then Registrar is liable for financial irregularities amounting to over ₹1.24 crore on account of regularisation of MTS staff to LDC posts, irregular payment towards medical insurance of Council members and purchase of costly gift items in violation

of prescribed financial rules and procedures. Further, around ₹13 lakh has also been recommended for recovery in lieu of the mandatory three-month notice period required for tendering resignation under provisions contained in the DMC Act and Rules.

The audit also recommended recovery of around ₹13 lakh related to the mandatory three-month notice period required before resignation under provisions of the DMC Act and Rules, it said.

Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the Government has a "zero-tolerance policy towards corruption, financial mismanagement and procedural violations in public institutions".

Ministers shift to Metro, EVs and online meet to save fuel



Minister Parvesh Verma uses cycle to reach office on Friday PANKAJ KUMAR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From travelling by metro and electric vehicles to shifting meetings online, Delhi ministers have begun adopting alternative transport and energy-saving measures following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to reduce fuel consumption and cut unnecessary expenditure.

On Friday, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa took the Metro to the Secretariat. PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh arrived at an NDMC event on a battery-powered bicycle. Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra drove an electric vehicle. Education Minister Ashish Sood held a virtual meeting with school principals instead of travelling. According to Sirsa, his Metro commute was "a small contribution towards a larger national mission" and urged citizens and young people to join in.

Mishra spoke of "Metro Monday" and work-from-home arrangements being promoted across departments. Parvesh Sahib Singh, arriving on his battery-powered bicycle, said the responsibility for fuel conservation "belongs to everyone,

not only the Government." Lighting inside the Delhi Secretariat has been reduced as per need to conserve electricity, an official said. Calling fuel conservation a "shared responsibility", Verma said the Government was encouraging work-from-home practices and greater use of public transport, including metro services, to reduce fuel consumption and traffic congestion.

Tourism, Art and Culture Minister Kapil Mishra travelled to the Delhi Secretariat in an electric vehicle and said initiatives such as "Metro Monday", work-from-home arrangements and reduced use of private vehicles were being promoted in the national Capital. Mishra said traders and industrialists in Delhi were also extending support to the campaign by implementing work-from-home policies and encouraging EV usage.

Amid Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to conserve petrol and diesel and turn energy conservation into a people's movement, Delhi Government has decided to limit the number of vehicles used by the chief minister, ministers and other officials in view of the prevailing global situation.

CM urges MLAs to take Govt initiatives to every home

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after unveiling a slew of measures to reduce fuel consumption, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday urged BJP legislators to take the Delhi Government's decisions and initiatives to every household across the National Capital.

The Chief Minister held a meeting with the legislators and said that given the present global crisis, rising fuel-related challenges and prevailing economic conditions, the Delhi Government was working with full commitment to turn the Prime Minister Narendra Modi's message into a mass movement.



cies to spread awareness about the Delhi Government's 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' campaign. Calling it a 90-day public awareness drive, the Chief Minister said the campaign was not merely a Government programme, but a collective effort in national interest in which every citizen had an important role to play.

The Chief Minister said the Government had taken several major decisions to implement the Prime Minister's appeal on the ground. As part of these measures, a two-day work-from-home system is being introduced in Government departments, except essential services. Private institutions and companies have also been advised to cooperate in this effort.

Rekha Gupta said people should also be informed about the decisions taken by the Government during this challenging period so that they too could adopt them in their daily lives.

Under these decisions, every Monday will be observed as

'Metro Monday', while citizens have also been urged to observe one 'No Vehicle Day' every week. The Government has also decided not to purchase any new petrol, diesel, CNG or hybrid vehicles for the next six months.

In addition, the temperature of air conditioners in government offices has been fixed between 24 and 26 degrees Celsius to ensure electricity savings. The Government has also decided to set up special 'Made in India' corners in malls and supermarkets across the Capital to promote indigenous products.

The CM said the present time was not just about Government efforts, but about fulfilling national responsibility through public participation. According to her, the Prime Minister Narendra Modi's message was not limited to fuel conservation alone, but represented a broader national campaign for an Aatmanirbhar Bharat, environmental protection and responsible citizenship.

NEET cancellation brings back uncertainty, stress for students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

For NEET aspirants, the cancellation of the paper has not just meant another test date, but the return of prolonged pressure and emotional fatigue that comes with months of preparation.

Students reacting to the Centre's announcement of a re-examination on June 21 said the decision, though aimed at ensuring fairness after allegations of irregularities, has left many of them mentally drained about having to restart their preparation cycle.

Dilpreet, a student staying in Old Rajinder Nagar, described the situation as "mentally harassing"



for aspirants. "If examinations cannot be conducted properly, then students' time should not be wasted. Many students spend years preparing for this exam. For some, it may even be their last attempt," she said.

Questioning the handling of alleged paper leaks, she said authorities should have ensured stronger security measures during the transportation and handling of

question papers instead of cancelling the exam later. Another student, Pawan, said many aspirants come from modest financial backgrounds and make significant sacrifices to prepare for NEET.

All the same, some students welcomed the Government's decision to shift NEET-UG to a computer-based format from next year, saying it could reduce the possibility of paper leaks and improve transparency.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Friday announced that the NEET-UG re-exam will be conducted on June 21 and said would shift to a computer-based format from next year as part of allegations of irregularities.

NEET candidate commits suicide in Azadpur, probe underway

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 20-year-old woman preparing for the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) allegedly died by suicide at her home in Delhi's Azadpur. Police learned about the incident only after her family took the body to a crematorium for last rites without prior police intimation, officials said on Friday.

As per reports, the NEET aspirant who had been preparing for the highly competitive medical entrance examination for the past few years was allegedly found dead at her residence on Thursday. Police

said no suicide note was recovered from the spot, and the exact reason behind the alleged suicide is yet to be established.

PTI reported that a PCR call was received at the Adarsh Nagar police station on Thursday, informing officers that a woman's body had been brought to the Kewal Park crematorium for last rites without prior police intimation. Speaking to a Delhi Police official, The Pioneer learnt that the call was made by the pandit of the crematorium after the body was brought for last rites without police intimation.

The Delhi Police official



also told *The Pioneer* that the incident took place on Thursday afternoon. PTI also reported that family members later told police they were unaware of the mandatory legal formalities in

such cases and had directly taken the body for cremation. The Delhi police official also told us that the reason behind this severe step is under investigation.

As per reports, police have

shifted the body to the mortuary at Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial Hospital for post-mortem examination.

A forensic team also visited the woman's residence to inspect the scene and collect evidence. Further investigation is underway.

Similar incidents of suicide have also been reported from Goa and UP's Lakhimpur Kheri, where two NEET aspirants took their lives days after the National Testing Agency (NTA) cancelled the NEET-UG examination held on May 3 amid allegations of a paper leak. A re-examination has been scheduled for June 21.

Counterfeit apparel worth lakhs seized by Delhi Police in raids

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police officials said on Friday that over 3,400 counterfeit branded jeans, specifically Levi's, Zara, Calvin Klein, and Tommy Hilfiger, along with thousands of fake labels imitating international apparel brands, were seized after simultaneous raids at four units in Naraina Industrial Area.

The crackdown, carried out by the District Investigation Unit (DIU) of the West district, exposed an alleged counterfeit garment manufacturing racket operating from industrial premises in Naraina, police said. Seven industrial stitching machines allegedly used to manufacture fake branded garments were also recovered.

According to police, the operation was launched following a complaint regarding the manufacturing and storage of counterfeit clothes in violation of trademark and copyright laws. After obtaining the necessary permissions, an FIR was registered at the Naraina Police Station on May 5 under Sections 103 and 104 of the Trade Marks Act and Sections 63 and 65 of the Copyright Act.

Police said that search and seizure warrants under Section 96 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) were obtained from a court before the raids on May 12 at multiple locations in the Naraina Industrial Area. Representatives of the complainant companies accompanied the raiding teams and identified the recovered products as counterfeit, officials said.

At a unit located in Naraina Industrial Area Phase-I, police arrested Vipin Sardana, a resident of Kirti Nagar. Officials said the premises contained 780 counterfeit Levi's jeans, 720 fake Zara jeans, 540 counterfeit Calvin Klein jeans, and 470 fake Tommy Hilfiger jeans. In addition, thousands of forged labels and four stitching machines were seized.

In another raid in the Naraina Industrial Area Phase-I, police apprehended Rishab Garg, a resident of Inderpuri. The team allegedly recovered 296 counterfeit Calvin Klein jeans, fake Levi's material, including unstitched portions and back pockets, 122 forged Calvin Klein tags and a stitching



Fake labels jeans were seized after raids at four units in Naraina Industrial Area

machine. A third raid at the Naraina Ring Road led to the arrest of Neeraj Bhambri, a resident of Noida. Police said they recovered 350 counterfeit Tommy Hilfiger jeans, samples of counterfeit jeans from several brands, and one industrial stitching machine from the premises.

During a fourth raid at Naraina Industrial Area Phase-I, police apprehended Ravi Prakash, who currently resides in Inderpuri. Officials said they seized 300 counterfeit Calvin Klein jeans, several counterfeit sample jeans, and one stitching machine.

Overall, police claimed to have recovered a total of 780 finished counterfeit Levi's jeans, 720 fake Zara jeans, 1,136 counterfeit Calvin Klein jeans, 820 fake Tommy Hilfiger jeans, in addition to thousands of forged labels, tags, and packaging materials linked to these brands.

The raids were conducted under the supervision of ACP Vijay Singh and his team. Deputy Commissioner of Police (West) Sharad Bhaskar Darade said further investigation is underway to trace the supply chain, manufacturers, distributors and other persons linked to the counterfeit garment racket.



POWERGRID
Transmitting Power,
Transforming Lives

Extract of the Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 (₹ in Crore)

S. No.	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter ended		Year ended		Quarter ended		Year ended	
		31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
1	Total Income for the period	11,954.70	12,482.39	46,995.88	46,325.32	11,970.69	12,590.80	47,684.43	47,459.38
2	Profit before Tax and Regulatory Deferral Account Balances	3,773.74	5,091.87	16,759.10	18,338.81	3,918.32	5,011.30	17,321.03	19,017.89
3	Net Profit after Tax for the period	4,552.80	4,336.17	15,921.00	15,353.57	4,546.33	4,142.87	15,927.95	15,521.44
4	Total Comprehensive Income comprising Net Profit after Tax and Other Comprehensive Income	4,547.17	4,254.45	16,066.78	15,114.24	4,597.65	4,065.38	16,193.78	15,285.16
5	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face value of share : ₹10/- each)	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60
6	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Balance sheet	90,628.01	82,915.05	90,628.01	82,915.05	91,193.43	83,362.21	91,193.43	83,362.21
7	Securities Premium Account	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28
8	Net worth	99,928.61	92,215.65	99,928.61	92,215.65	1,00,494.03	92,662.81	1,00,494.03	92,662.81
9	Total Borrowings	1,48,009.01	1,30,964.96	1,48,009.01	1,30,964.96	1,48,009.01	1,30,964.96	1,48,009.01	1,30,964.96
10	Debt Equity Ratio	1.48	1.42	1.48	1.42	1.47	1.41	1.47	1.41
11	Earnings per equity share including movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	4.90	4.66	17.12	16.51	4.89	4.46	17.13	16.69
12	Earnings per equity share excluding movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	9.00	4.61	20.15	16.21	8.94	4.40	20.11	16.39
13	Bonds Redemption Reserve	2,721.31	3,193.24	2,721.31	3,193.24	2,721.31	3,193.24	2,721.31	3,193.24
14	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	2.11	1.55	1.54	1.48	2.25	1.57	1.61	1.53
15	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	4.13	3.83	3.93	3.94	4.85	4.16	4.57	4.28

(*) Figures for the quarters have not been annualized

Notes:

- The above is an extract of the Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 and 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Complete Financial Results are available on the Investors section of our website <https://www.powergrid.in> and under Corporates Section of BSE Limited & National Stock Exchange of India Limited at <https://www.bseindia.com> and <https://www.nseindia.com> respectively. These can also be accessed by scanning Quick Response Code:
- Previous periods figures have been rearranged/reclassified wherever considered necessary.

Place: Gurugram
Date : 15th May, 2026

For and on behalf of POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
Sd/-
G Ravisankar, Director (Finance)
DIN: 08816101



POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Corporate Office: "Saudamini", Plot No. - 2, Sector - 29, Gurugram - 122 001(Haryana), Tel.: 0124-2571700-719
Registered Office: B-9, Qutab Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi - 110016, Tel: 011-26560112, 26560121, CIN : L40101DL1989GOI038121

Follow us :



www.powergrid.in

IN FOCUS



People at a stall during the 3rd annual exhibition-cum-sale of Ratnagiri Alphonso mangoes in Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh

PTI

Governance institutions must reinvent themselves: Jitendra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union minister Jitendra Singh on Friday said that administrative training and governance institutions across the country must reinvent themselves and shun stereotype models to remain relevant.

Addressing the concluding session of the National Departmental Summit on "Institutionalising Capacity Building: From Training to Performance-Linked Governance" through virtual mode, he said Mission Karmayogi is steadily moving towards an AI-integrated governance framework linking capacity building, competency development, technology and



public service delivery.

The National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building (NPCSCB), popularly known as the Mission Karmayogi, aims to create a competent civil service rooted in the Indian ethos, with a shared understanding of the country's priori-

ties, working in harmony for an effective and efficient public service delivery.

Singh, the Minister of State for Personnel, said governance reforms today require transparency, time-line discipline, ease of procedures and optimum use of technology supported

by innovation and human sensitivity.

Referring to governance reforms undertaken in recent years, he said annual grievances received on the Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS) portal have increased from nearly two lakh in 2014 to more than 25-30 lakh presently, reflecting growing public trust due to improved responsiveness and accountability.

Singh also referred to the success of Digital Life Certificates, noting that nearly 10-11 crore certificates have already been generated, enabling pensioners to complete formalities digitally without physical visits.

Totally false: PM Modi on reports of Govt planning to levy tax on foreign travel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday dismissed reports that the government is considering levying a tax or a cess or a surcharge on foreign travel as "totally false".

The prime minister said this in response to a new report suggesting that the government is considering levying a tax or a cess or a surcharge on foreign travel but no final decision has been taken yet.

"This is totally false. Not an iota of truth in this. There is no question of putting such restrictions on foreign travel. We remain committed to improving 'Ease of Doing Business' and 'Ease of Living' for our people," Modi said in



a post on X. It is rare that the prime minister himself has denied a media report.

The report, quoting sources, claimed that the proposal to levy a cess or a tax or a surcharge on foreign travel is being discussed at the highest levels.

Maharashtra Govt mandates marathi for revenue hearings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government on Friday made the use of Marathi mandatory in hearings as well as in all orders passed by authorities in quasi-judicial proceedings in the revenue department.

Revenue Minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule announced a new standard operating procedure (SoP) for these proceedings.

Authorities issued a 29-page Government resolution laying down procedures for handling quasi-judicial cases filed before revenue officers.

"Under the guidance of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, we intend to make the revenue administration more citizen-centric and dynamic," Bawankule said.

The Government considered earlier directives, recommendations from divisional commissioners, field-level instructions and observations of the Bombay High Court and the Supreme Court while



framing the revised procedures for quasi-judicial functioning, he said.

The new SoP also makes it mandatory for all revenue officers to conduct hearings at least twice a week, preferably on Tuesdays and Fridays, while adjournments will be allowed only once and only for valid reasons.

All interim and final orders will have to be uploaded on the 'e-QJ Court' system and issued only with digital signatures. No order can be passed without hearing both parties and recording proper reasoning. Speaking orders should be issued within a maximum period of eight weeks.

NDMC hands out compassionate jobs, health cards to staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday distributed appointment letters to 109 people appointed on compassionate grounds and issued medical health cards to 878 contractual employees of the New Delhi Municipal Council. She described the measures as part of the Government's effort to build a more sensitive and transparent administration.

The programme was organised by the NDMC at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road. Delhi Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj, NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra, Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal, and other council members attended the event.

Addressing employees and officials, the Chief Minister said the NDMC was not merely a civic institution but a support system for thousands of workers and families serving the nation-



al Capital. She said employees working in the NDMC area contributed directly to the image and functioning of Delhi as the country's administrative centre.

The Chief Minister said the compassionate appointments had brought financial and emotional support to 109 families of deceased employees. She added that the initiative was not only about providing jobs, but also about ensuring long-

term stability for affected families. The Chief Minister noted that nearly 90 women were among those who received appointment letters. She expressed confidence that the new recruits would work with dedication in strengthening the vision of a developed Delhi and a developed India.

The Chief Minister said rising medical costs often place severe financial pressure on families and added

that the health cards would provide relief and security during emergencies. Referring to the broader governance approach of the Government, the Chief Minister said the administration was working on the principle of inclusive development and aimed to ensure that employees and citizens received services with dignity and fairness.

Delhi Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the initiatives reflected the Government's responsibility towards workers and their families. He said dependents of deceased employees had received an opportunity for financial stability, while contractual employees would no longer have to worry about arranging large amounts of money during medical emergencies.

Singh also recalled the NDMC's earlier decision to regularise around 4,400 temporary employees. He said the measures were being implemented as part of the Government's duty towards society and not for

political gain.

New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj described the decisions as humanitarian measures that addressed long-pending demands of employees. She said the approval of compassionate appointments and medical facilities reflected the administration's commitment to employee welfare.

NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra said the appointment of 109 dependents demonstrated the council's commitment to supporting families of employees who had spent years serving the organisation. He added that the council wanted to ensure dignity, emotional support, and financial protection for affected families.

Chandra said the medical card scheme covered 878 contractual workers across 38 categories, including engineers, nurses, technical staff, and clerical employees. He described the initiative as an important step towards social security and inclusive welfare.

Political stability driving growth in Northeast: Meghalaya CM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma on Friday said that political stability and firm leadership have put the Northeast on the path of rapid economic growth, asserting that the region is now ready to absorb large-scale investments.

Speaking at a curtain raiser of the upcoming North East India Infrastructure Summit and Exhibition in New Delhi, Sangma claimed the region remained constrained in the past due to the absence of an enabling political environment. "The overall environment and political situation make the timing perfect," he said, highlighting the growing investor interest in the region.

"In the Northeast, many opportunities that could not be unlocked earlier are now opening up because of the right leadership, political stability and consistent follow-up," Sangma said.

Bhojshala complex a temple: HC

The Bhojshala dispute reached the High Court in 2022 after Ranjana Agnihotri and others, on behalf of a Hindu advocacy group, sought a declaration of the site's religious character and complete worship rights for Hindus. The petition also sought a ban on *namaz* inside the premises, formation of a trust and return of the Vagdevi idol currently kept in the British Museum.

In 2024, the ASI conducted a 98-day scientific survey of the Bhojshala complex. Later, on January 23, 2026, the SC allowed uninterrupted worship on Vasant Panchami. Regular hearings in the High Court began on April 6 and concluded on May 12 before the verdict was delivered on Friday.

Prices of petrol, diesel raised by ₹3 a litre

When diesel costs more, moving anything costs more. And when moving things costs more, buying things costs more.

The most immediate pressure is on transportation costs. Petrol price hikes increase commuting expenses for people using cars and bikes, while higher diesel prices affect buses, trucking networks and goods transportation across the country. Over time, this can translate into higher auto fares, cab fares and freight charges, especially if elevated fuel prices persist. The impact does not stop with transportation.

Since a large share of India's food supply moves through road transport, higher diesel prices often end up affecting kitchen budgets as well. Vegetables, fruits, milk, grains and packaged products become more expensive to transport, and these additional costs are eventually passed on to consumers. If fuel prices remain elevated for long, food inflation could also worsen.

Public sector oil marketing companies had kept fuel price unchanged for 11 weeks despite a surge in input cost, but passed on part of the increase once operations became financially unsustainable. India consumes about 5 million barrels of oil a day, which allows the current stock to cover around 18 days of demand.

Several opposition parties attacked the Government over the hike in prices of petrol and diesel, warning that the move would worsen inflation and hamper economic growth. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said the public was paying the price for the Modi Government's "mistake". BJP, however, defended the hike, claiming that India managed to shield citizens from the global oil shock for more than two months while implementing only a "limited and calibrated" rise even as several countries witnessed steeper increases.

This is the lowest increase in price as compared to the United States, the United Kingdom, European countries and United Arab Emirates which witnessed steep hikes. Data shows countries such as Myanmar, Malaysia, Pakistan and

the United States have seen petrol prices rise anywhere between 40 per cent and over 89 per cent, while diesel prices in some markets have jumped by more than 100 per cent.

Paper setter arrested in NEET leak case

Students allegedly paid several lakh rupees to attend the sessions where they wrote the questions down in their notebooks. These handwritten notes have been found to match the actual NEET-UG 2026 question paper held on 3 May 2026 exactly. CBI teams have conducted searches at multiple locations across the country and seized several incriminating documents, electronic gadgets, and mobile phones. Detailed forensic and technical analysis of the seized material is currently underway.

The scope of Kulkarni's role remain unclear. The first warning came when a parent reported that 42 chemistry questions in a mock test by a Latour coaching institute matched the actual NEET paper. A 28-member CBI team was then deployed across Latour, known for its coaching factories. On Thursday, an Ayurveda practitioner from Ahilyanagar and a beauty salon owner from Pune were taken in. All attention now turns to Kulkarni, whose role may expose a bigger conspiracy. CCTV footage from two coaching centres has been seized, and digital evidence is under review. The agency has not ruled out the involvement of insiders from the National Testing Agency or public servants. A senior official hinted, "This is not the end. It may be just the beginning."

The probe has confirmed the paper was not just 'guessed' but stolen and monetised as a commercial product. The CBI has charged Kulkarni with conspiracy, cheating, and breach of trust. More arrests are expected as the case expands.

PM Modi supports peace in West Asia

"We condemn the attacks on the UAE," Modi said during his opening remarks at the bilateral meeting. "The way UAE has been targeted is not acceptable, but the way UAE has handled the current situation with restraint is praiseworthy."

The UAE, home to a major US military base, has faced Iranian strikes amid the ongoing US-Israel conflict with Iran that began on February 28.

Highlighting the broader global impact of the conflict, Modi said, "India is ready to extend all possible support to bring peace in West Asia."

The two sides signed strategic collaborations across seven key sectors. In a post on social media, Modi said the agreements in energy, defence, infrastructure, shipping and advanced technology would provide "fresh impetus" to the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

"In another important development, UAE announced investments worth USD 5 billion in India. This will further deepen economic ties," he added.

FROM PAGE - 1

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Limited signed an agreement with Abu Dhabi National Oil Company to enhance strategic collaboration in energy security, including petroleum reserves and possible cooperation in LNG and LPG storage facilities.

Another agreement focused on long-term LPG supply arrangements aimed at ensuring energy stability and strengthening bilateral energy cooperation. The developments come amid heightened concerns in India over possible disruptions to crude oil and gas supplies through the Strait of Hormuz, a critical maritime route for India's energy imports.

India and the UAE also signed a framework agreement for strategic defence cooperation to strengthen defence manufacturing, technology sharing, innovation and regional security cooperation. Additional agreements included the establishment of a ship repair centre in Gujarat's Vadinar, cooperation in ports and coastal infrastructure, and a skill development arrangement in ship repair.

The two countries also agreed to establish a supercomputer cluster to support India's artificial intelligence ambitions.

The MEA said the UAE's \$5 billion investment commitment would help generate jobs and strengthen markets, underscoring Abu Dhabi's long-term confidence in India's growth story.

Apart from strategic and economic issues, discussions between the two leaders also covered the blue economy, fintech, defence cooperation and people-to-people ties.

Concluding the visit, Modi described the discussions as "highly productive."

"Held extensive discussions with my brother, His Highness Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, on ways to further deepen the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. I am confident that the outcomes of this visit will further strengthen our friendship and contribute to growth and prosperity," he said.

In a special gesture reflecting the significance of the visit, Sheikh Mohamed personally received Modi at the Abu Dhabi airport. The Prime Minister was accorded a ceremonial guard of honour, while his aircraft was escorted by UAE military jets. The visit comes at a time of shifting geopolitical equations in West Asia, with widening differences among Gulf powers over oil production, the Strait of Hormuz blockade and regional alignments involving Israel and Iran. The evolving dynamics involving the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Iran are increasingly influencing India's strategic calculations in the region.

No trust in US; India our friend: Iran FM Araghchi

Speaking about the ongoing tensions and negotiations between Tehran and Washington, Araghchi sharply criticised the US and said, "Iran has every reason to not to trust US, American have every reason to trust Iran."

The Iranian foreign minister is in the nation-

al Capital to attend the BRICS meeting and expressed gratitude for India's hospitality during his visit. He also highlighted the deep historical and civilisational ties between India and Iran.

"India and Iran are ancient civilizations and friendly countries. We have had very good relations with India," Araghchi said. His remarks come amid renewed uncertainty over diplomatic engagement between Tehran and Washington following recent tensions linked to Iran's nuclear programme and regional security issues.

Araghchi said negotiations with the US will move forward only if Washington demonstrated seriousness and consistency in its diplomatic commitments. He noted that mixed signals from the US administration had further deepened mistrust between the two countries.

The Iranian minister also referred to the tense situation surrounding the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most strategically important oil shipping routes. He described the situation as "very complicated" but maintained that commercial passage through the waterway would continue under certain conditions.

The comments follow recent statements by US President Donald Trump, who urged Iran to quickly reach an agreement and ensure uninterrupted access through the Strait of Hormuz. Trump also reiterated that Iran should not be allowed to develop nuclear weapons.

Despite the sharp rhetoric, Iranian officials have continued to signal that diplomacy remains possible if economic sanctions and military pressure are reduced. Earlier this year, Araghchi had said that a potential agreement with the US was "within reach" if all sides prioritised diplomacy.

NEET-UG to be re-held on May 12

Addressing a press conference on Wednesday, Pradhan said, after irregularities surfaced last time, the Radhakrishnan Committee was constituted, and its recommendations were implemented. "Despite that, this incident occurred. Therefore, our first step was to cancel the examination. To those creating fear and disturbances, I want to say through you: stay away from the upcoming examination process. Otherwise, they will have to face punishment," he added.

"We did not want any mafia conspiracy or money power to snatch away your seat. We did not want that to happen. That is why we had to take a tough decision. As guardians, as officials entrusted with responsibility, and as a minister, we are all deeply saddened and concerned by what has happened," he said.

Pradhan added that the duration of the re-test has been extended by 15 minutes and the re-examination will be held using the pen-paper model. He further stated that candidates will also get to choose their preferred test cities again and admit cards for the re-test will be issued by June 14. The minister also said NEET-UG will be Computer-Based Test (CBT) from next year as part of reforms in view of allegations of irregularities linked to it.

"CBT mode of exam is comparatively better

than OMR. It is a bit protected. Cybercrime has become a big world in itself. There are challenges, however, we will have to trust the system of our country," he further said.

Sources also said that this time the logistics and security apparatus may be handed over to the paramilitary forces precisely CISF to use the forces as a deterrent for the mafia in the system.

"The examination was conducted on May 3. By May 7, objections were received through the NTA's grievance redressal system stating that certain questions appearing in the alleged 'guess papers' had also appeared in this year's question set. Immediately, discussions were held, and both the NTA and the Government, along with the Higher Education Department, initiated a preliminary inquiry," he said.

Pradhan said the Government has handed over the case to the CBI and expressed confidence in the probe. "CBI has rightly said... no one will be spared. Whether someone is within the NTA or outside it, no one will be spared," he said.

Pradhan said students' future remains the Government's topmost priority, adding that there will be "zero tolerance" for any irregularities found in the conduct of the NEET-UG. Strict action is being taken, he said.

Gautam Adani pushes to settle US fraud case

Adani raised more than \$3 billion in loans and bonds by hiding corruption from lenders and investors, prosecutors said.

The *New York Times* on Friday reported that Adani offered \$10 billion investment in US to avoid bribery charges in the US.

The industrialist has hired lawyer close to US President Trump to settle the case. The offer was made by the advocate to US Justice Department.

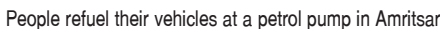
"Now, according to several people with knowledge of the case, the Justice Department is planning to drop the charges altogether. The reversal came after the Indian billionaire, Gautam Adani, hired a new legal team led by Robert J Giuffra Jr, one of President Trump's personal lawyers," the report read.

"Giuffra's efforts on Adani's behalf culminated in a previously unreported meeting last month at the Justice Department's headquarters in Washington, according to people familiar with the meeting. Giuffra ticked through about 100 slides outlining why prosecutors lacked basic evidence, as well as the jurisdiction even to bring the case, one of the people said, according to the report."

"Another slide also offered the Government a sweetener: If prosecutors dropped the charges, Adani would be willing to invest \$10 billion in the US economy and create 15,000 jobs, echoing a pledge he made in the wake of Trump's election. While prosecutors later told Giuffra that the \$10 billion investment would play no role in the resolution of the case, his offer received a favorable response from at least one senior Justice Department official at the meeting, according to the people familiar with the meeting," added the *New York Times* report.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The attack came as petrol and diesel prices were hiked by ₹3 per litre each on Friday, marking the first increase in more than four years, as



"The ₹3 shock has already arrived, the rest of the 'vasooli (recovery)' will be done in instalments," the Leader of

Kharge said when diesel prices rise, inflation has a cascading effect across the country, adversely affecting

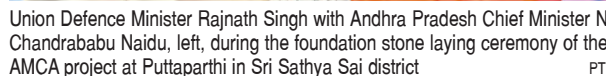
The CPI-M Polit Bureau strongly condemned the Centre for raising petrol, diesel and CNG prices, saying the hike would impose a greater burden on the people already reeling under inflation, unemployment, stag-

Hours after the hike, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav took a swipe at Modi's call to conserve fuel, saying that the bicycle, the SP's official election symbol, was the only alternative, seemingly emphasising that his party alone could offer a solution.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puttaparthi (Andhra Pra

The two leaders laid the foundation for the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) programme infrastructure. "A new era is starting today in Andhra Pradesh's history, and a historic chapter is being written in India's defence history. Four major projects are starting in today's foundation stone laying ceremony. Beside them, eight drone companies are also starting a drone city in Kurnool," Rajnath Singh said, addressing a public meeting.

Observing that the world is facing many challenges today, he said that during

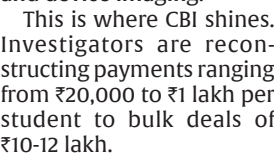


Noting that the project in Puttaparthi was being developed by Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA) which is a part of the DRDO, the defence minister said it is

Reflecting on other projects, Rajnath Singh said Bharat Dynamics Limited will manufacture advanced autonomous underwater systems, torpedoes and countermeasure systems with an investment of Rs 480 crore.

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The agency coordinated seamlessly with state police, absorbing local leads while asserting federal oversight. This hybrid model, State boots on the ground, central firepower, is standard CBI protocol in inter-state crimes, but was executed with



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

Strong states build a strong nation, the CM said while asserting that zonal councils have been providing new direction to development, administrative coordination and national unity.

CensusIndia2021



States Focus



3 IPS OFFICERS SUSPENDED OVER MISHANDLING IN RG KAR CASE

The West Bengal Government on Friday suspended three senior IPS officers for their alleged mishandling and dereliction of duty during the initial phase of investigation into the RG Kar hospital rape-murder case, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said. Announcing the decision at the state secretariat, Adhikari said the suspension of former Kolkata Police Commissioner Vineet Goyal and ex-deputy commissioners Indira Mukherjee and Abhishek Gupta was ordered in the wake of a departmental probe initiated against them. The chief minister said that the three officers were allegedly involved in the "mishandling" of the case, "offering money to the victim's parents as a bribe" and addressing an "unauthorised press conference" in connection with the gruesome crime, which took place in August, 2024.

(PTI)



BIHAR GOVT TRANSFERS IAS OFFICERS IN MAJOR RESHUFFLE

The Bihar Government on Friday undertook an administrative reshuffle by transferring and giving additional charges to several IAS officers posted in various departments. According to a notification issued by the General Administration Department, K Senthil Kumar (IAS-1996 batch), Additional Chief Secretary (ACS) of the Sugarcane Industry Department, has been appointed ACS of the Labour Resources and Migrant Workers Welfare Department. He has also been given additional charge of the Backward Classes and Extremely Backward Classes Welfare Department. Several officials were also relieved of their additional responsibilities.

(PTI)

No information on post-poll violence in Bengal: Suwendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday said his Government has no information on incidents of post-poll violence as alleged by the Opposition TMC, and asserted that action would be taken after proper verification of such charges. He was responding to the allegations of post-poll violence raised by Leader of the Opposition Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay in the West Bengal Assembly.

Chattopadhyay, speaking during the first session of the newly constituted assembly, alleged that several people had been forced to flee their homes due to violence across the State after the Assembly elections.

"Violence has been taking place in several places. Many people are homeless now. The Government should take strict action," the TMC legislator said in the House.

In response, Adhikari said, "We have no information



West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari addresses a press conference at Nabanna in Howrah district, West Bengal

PTI

about such incidents...If anyone has been displaced, the police and administration will ensure they are returned home." The CM asserted that those involved in violence would not be spared, and the law would take its course in all genuine cases.

The TMC also staged a walkout for a brief period after BJP legislators raised the "chor chor" (thieves) slogan in the Assembly. The members of the Opposition party were also absent during

the Speaker's election but later returned to the House.

BJP MLA Rathindra Bose was elected unopposed as the Speaker of the West Bengal Assembly, becoming the first legislator from the northern part of the State to hold the chair. After the Speaker's election, Adhikari said the proceedings of the Assembly will be telecast live so that people know what is happening inside the House. He said the House would play a key role in fulfilling the

aspirations of the people and function strictly in accordance with Constitutional principles and established rules. "We will move the assembly forward, keeping the Constitution in mind," the chief minister said.

He also stressed the need for a "strong and constructive Opposition" in the House, reiterating that democratic functioning requires space for dissenting voices.

"We want constructive opposition. The assembly is not a place for clashes. In constitutional terms, the House belongs to the opposition," Adhikari said, adding that speaking time in the House would be shared on a 50-50 basis. The CM also said the Government does not want any legislator to face suspension and stressed the need to maintain decorum in the House.

"We do not want any MLA to be out of the House for long. Language and conduct must remain within democratic limits," he said.

West Bengal Government signs MoU to implement PM SHRI Schools scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Ministry of Education on Friday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the West Bengal Government to implement the PM SHRI Schools initiative in the State.

The PM SHRI (Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India) scheme is a centrally sponsored initiative launched on September 7, 2022, to upgrade over 14,500 existing Government schools into model institutions that showcase the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.



West Bengal, under the earlier Mamata Banerjee-led TMC Government, had opposed joining the scheme, citing the state's autonomy on education, which often led to funding disputes with the Centre.

Following the change in Government in the State,

the new BJP administration led by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari decided to implement the initiative.

The MoU to implement the scheme was signed in the presence of School Education and Literacy Secretary Sanjay Kumar between the Department of School Education and Literacy under the Ministry of Education and the West Bengal Government.

The agreement was signed by Additional Secretary Dheeraj Sahu, on behalf of the Centre, and Additional Chief Secretary Binod Kumar representing the State Government.

Ex-TMC minister Ghosh appears before ED in recruitment scam case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Former West Bengal food minister Rathin Ghosh on Friday appeared before the ED in connection with the alleged civic recruitment scam case after skipping summons on five earlier occasions.

Ghosh reached the ED office at the CGO Complex in Salt Lake around 10 am and said he was unaware of the reason behind the summons. "I do not know why I have been called. I will know once I go inside," he told reporters before entering the office. During the election period,



Rathin Ghosh

the central agency had summoned him five times, but he did not appear, citing political engagements and campaign-related commitments.

ED officials are expected to question him in connection with the ongoing probe into

allegations of recruitment in civic bodies in exchange for money.

The development comes days after former fire services minister Sujit Bose was arrested by the ED in the same case following prolonged questioning. Bose had also received multiple ED summonses from April onwards, including during the Assembly election period.

He had approached the Calcutta High Court seeking time, citing his involvement in election campaigning.

After the elections, Bose appeared before ED investigators on May 1 and May 11, the day he was arrested.

Arunachal bans foreign travel for ministers, Government officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

The Arunachal Pradesh Government has rolled out a series of initiatives aimed at reducing unnecessary expenditure and encouraging sustainable practices, following the Prime Minister's appeal for cutting down fuel consumption and spending more wisely in view of the West Asia crisis.

The State Cabinet has announced several key decisions focused on fiscal discipline, digital governance and energy conservation, officials said. The measures include a one-year ban on foreign travel by ministers and Government officials, a 50 per cent reduction in the convoy size of the CM, deputy CM and ministers, and a 'Virtual First' policy for official meetings to slash travel-related costs, they said.

The State Government also resolved to implement "100 per cent e-office and paperless governance across departments by March 2027" to streamline official func-



tioning. The Cabinet also decided that no new vehicles would be procured except for emergency services, the officials said. Government departments and institutions have also been encouraged to promote carpooling and greater use of public transport, they said.

As part of the State's energy conservation strategy, air conditioners in Government offices will now maintain a temperature of 24 degrees Celsius and above. Besides, only 5-star rated energy-efficient products would be considered for government procurement, they said. "The

measures additionally emphasise sustainability and self-reliance, with directives to encourage organic farming practices, minimise edible oil usage in institutions and strengthen the 'Buy Swadeshi, Buy Local' initiative to support locally produced goods," an official said.

Emphasising that the Centre was trying to shield people from the adverse impact of the conflict in West Asia, PM Narendra Modi had on May 10 called for judicious use of fuel, postponement of gold purchases and foreign travel, among other measures, to strengthen the economy.

Kuki and Naga hostages freed by armed groups in Manipur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

Thirty-one of the 38 people belonging to the Kuki and Naga communities, who were held hostage by armed groups in Manipur's Kangpokpi and Senapati districts, were released, police said on Friday.

These people were taken to unknown areas after suspected militants shot dead three church leaders and injured four others in



Kangpokpi on Wednesday, while a civilian was gunned down and his wife was

wounded in Noney district. "Twelve Naga women from Konsakhul village, who

BJP slams Karnataka Govt over saffron shawl ban in schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A political row erupted on Friday over the Congress-led Karnataka Government's clarification that saffron shawls would not be allowed in educational institutions, with the BJP alleging that it is pursuing "appeasement and vote-bank politics".

The controversy flared up after Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah said on Thursday that saffron shawls

would not be allowed in educational institutions under the State Government's order on religious symbols, while practices already in existence, such as hijab, turbans, rudraksha beads and sacred threads (janeu) would continue to be permitted.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the Congress Government is pursuing appeasement politics and termed it an "Aurangzebi Government". "This Government allows the



Shehzad Poonawalla

wearing of hijab inside institutions, which the Supreme Court and high court had not

allowed. But you cannot wear a 'bhagwa' (saffron) shawl or 'bhagwa' angavastam. This is the mindset of the Siddaramaiah Government," Poonawalla said in a video post on X. He alleged that the Congress Government can go to any extent for appeasement politics and accused the party of "abusing Sanatan" in the past as well.

"They have shown Hindu hatred, from terms like 'bhagwa terror' and 'Hindu terror' to abusing Sanatan.

"We have seen how Congress leaders in Tamil Nadu have abused Sanatan. In Telangana, they said Congress means Muslims. They seek Muslim reservation in the name of vote-bank politics and appeasement," he alleged. Poonawalla further alleged that the Siddaramaiah Government has adopted a discriminatory policy and claimed that it had earlier announced a "Muslim-only budget" and "Muslim colonies".

Drones are now claws in the sky, says IAF Chief AP Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Underlining the critical importance of drones and other unmanned aerial systems (UAS) in modern-day warfare, IAF Chief A P Singh on Friday said these systems are no more just eyes in the sky, rather they are now akin to "claws in the sky," being an extension of air power.

Making this point here in his address at a defence seminar on unmanned aerial systems, the IAF chief asserted that in any modern aerial threat, complete domain awareness is the key, and there should be "total coordination" among the three services which will be operating in the same airspace. The seminar was organised by the think-tank Centre for Aerospace Power & Strategic



IAF Chief A P Singh

Studies (CAPSS) and the Indian Military Review (IMR) publication.

"We have seen what happens...if you don't have domain awareness, you don't know where your people are and where others are. We've seen what happened to F-15s in Kuwait. The fratricide part. So we cannot afford to have things

like that," he said, referring to the incident on March 1 in which three US F-15E Strike Eagles went down over Kuwait due to an apparent friendly fire, according to the US CENTCOM.

The drones, UAS and counter-UAS are very relevant today; it is a reality and not something for the future, the IAF chief said. "So, there is no

denying that the battlefield has shifted. We are shifting totally from those very concentrated air power to a sort of decentralised and autonomous way," he added.

The IAF chief underlined that the UAS is an "extension of air power". "So all the rules of air power will apply when you use the UAS, just remember that. And, there are no more eyes in the sky. They are like claws in the sky now. We've seen it in the recent conflicts that have taken place. And we have realised that during Operation Sindoor, and this part cannot be forgotten," he asserted.

"And, when it comes to counter-UAS, it is like a cat-and-mouse game. You develop technology in one field; the counter technology has to develop along with

it. Because that is how the game can be played, otherwise, one side will have total advantage," the IAF chief said. "You can't always have force versus force. It has to be force versus defence and others." He recalled the key role of the Indian Air Force during Operation Sindoor, the decisive military action by India during May last year.

"I think we've done reasonably well in Op Sindoor. And why that happened was because there was coordination. Without coordination, without a central agency coordinating it. Without having that IACCS (Integrated Air Command and Control System) become a nerve centre, whether it is counter-UAS or counter-weapon or counter-aircraft, it wouldn't have been possible," he said.

Monsoon likely to hit Kerala early on May 26: Met dept

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The southwest monsoon is expected to set in early over Kerala on May 26, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said in its forecast on Friday. The monsoon, the primary rain-bearing system, normally arrives in Kerala around June 1 and advances northwards to cover other parts of the country.

The onset of monsoon in the state marks the beginning of the southwest monsoon season (June to September). Last year, the onset of the monsoon happened on May 24.

"This year, the southwest monsoon is likely to set in over Kerala on May 26 with a



model error of ± 4 days (could occur four days before or after)," the IMD said.

The weather office also added that conditions were favourable for the monsoon to advance over parts of the South Bay of Bengal, Andaman Sea, and Andaman and Nicobar Islands during the next 24 hours.

"The advance of the southwest monsoon over the

Indian mainland is marked by monsoon onset over Kerala and is an important indicator characterising the transition from the hot and dry season to the rainy season," the IMD said.

"As the monsoon progresses northward, relief from scorching summer temperatures is experienced over the areas," it added.

The four-month monsoon season brings almost 70 per cent of the country's annual rainfall. It is critical for agriculture and crops, for the economy as a whole, and to recharge reservoirs and aquifers.

The IMD has said that India might receive below-normal rainfall this year during the monsoon season.

UCC to ensure justice for every citizen, says Assam CM Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday said the proposed Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will ensure equal application of law for all citizens, with special emphasis on the rights of women and children. He asserted that tribal communities will be kept out of the purview of the UCC to protect their traditions and customs.

“The Uniform Civil Code in Assam will ensure equal application of the rule of law for everyone and guarantee fair rights to all, especially women and children,” Sarma said in a post on X. “The Janjatiya Samaj of Assam will not be under the purview of #UCCAssam to protect their customs and traditions,” he added, referring to the tribal



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma visited Batadrava Thaan, the birthplace of Mahapurush Srimanta Sankaradeva and offered his prayers at the holy site

communities. The first Cabinet meeting of the new Government on Wednesday had approved the implementation of the UCC in the state, with tribals to be kept outside its purview, Sarma had said after the decision.

Sharing two slides on social media on the proposed UCC’s

objectives, the CM said it is about “one state, one law”, which will ensure a single legal system for marriage, divorce and succession.

Legal marriageable age will be fixed at 18 years for women and 21 years for men, with mandatory reporting of all marriages and live-in rela-

tionships within 60 days. “ST and Adivasi communities fully exempted to preserve customs,” Sarma added.

Maintaining that the UCC is to ensure “justice for every citizen”, Sarma said it will entail that spouses, children and parents share equal inheritance.

The UCC will have explicit maintenance rights for women in marriages and live-in relationships, and guaranteed legitimacy for all children and mother-focused custody for kids under the age of five years.

There will be provision for strict penalties for false statements to ensure legal records integrity, Sarma added.

The draft of the UCC Bill will be laid in the Assembly on May 26, Sarma said on Wednesday.

Congress slams Maharashtra Government for suppressing Konkan farmers’ protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Congress on Friday slammed the BJP-led Mahayuti Government for suppressing a protest march seeking financial assistance for mango and cashew farmers from the Konkan region, asserting that the agitation would continue till their demands are met.

State Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal claimed that even before the march began, the police detained several leaders and activists, including Swabhimani Shetkari Sanghatana president and former MP Raju Shetty, Rashtriya Samaj Paksha leader Mahadev Jankar, Shiv Sena’s Vinayak Raut, and Sena MP Arvind Sawant, among others.

He said that farmers cultivating mango and cashew in Konkan were facing severe hardship and had been agitating for the past three months seeking financial assistance.

A protest march was organised



State Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal

from Girgaum Chowpatty in south Mumbai to the official residence of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, ‘Varsha’, to press for their demands.

“The Congress has extended full support to the farmers’ agitation. The Government is trying to suppress the voices of farmers, workers and the Opposition by not allowing

democratic protests and marches,” Sapkal alleged.

He said the protesters were demanding ₹5 lakh per hectare compensation for mango farmers and ₹3 lakh per hectare for cashew cultivators.

“The struggle will continue until these demands are met,” he said.

Amit Shah to inaugurate Modern Madhur Dairy Plant in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Gandhinagar

Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah is scheduled to inaugurate a newly built, fully automated milk processing and packaging plant of Madhur Dairy at Dashela village in Gandhinagar district on May 17, 2026.

Constructed at an estimated cost of ₹128 crore, the advanced facility has an initial milk processing capacity of 2.5 lakh litres per day, which can be expanded to 5 lakh litres daily as per future demand. With the commissioning of the new plant, Madhur Dairy’s overall milk processing and packaging capacity

is expected to reach 5 lakh litres per day, strength-



ening its position as one of the leading cooperative dairy unions in Gandhinagar district.

Officials said the expansion will enable the dairy to process the entire milk procurement from local producers while ensuring better returns for farmers and improved availability of quality milk and dairy products for consumers. The project is also expected to

enhance production capabilities for products marketed under the Madhur and Amul brands.

Affiliated with Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation, Madhur Dairy has been working to support dairy farmers and supply affordable dairy products since its establishment in 1971. The cooperative began operations with just four milk societies and a daily procurement of around 6,400 litres of milk.

Over the decades, the dairy has recorded steady growth. During 2025-26, average daily milk procurement reportedly reached around 2.76 lakh litres, while annual turnover has risen to nearly ₹628 crore from just ₹7 lakh in its early years.



Assam MLA and former minister Chandra Mohan Patowary took oath as Pro-tem Speaker of 16th Assam Legislative Assembly, administered by the Governor of Assam Laxman Acharya at Lok Bhavan on Friday

Rajasthan CM inaugurates first semiconductor cluster

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Jaipur

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Friday inaugurated the State’s first semiconductor cluster at Bhiwadi and said the Government had implemented 35 policies over the past two years to promote investment and create an industry-friendly environment.

Addressing a virtual event from the chief minister’s residence, Sharma said the State Government was committed to encouraging investment across sectors and positioning Rajasthan as a major industrial destination.

He said work was progressing on connecting Rajasthan with Delhi through the Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS) via Haryana and on implementing the Yamuna water agreement.

The chief minister also said the Government planned to establish a major industrial area near Bandikui in Alwar district.

Calling the semiconductor cluster a significant achievement, Sharma said Rajasthan was rapidly

advancing in renewable energy, including solar and wind power, as part of efforts to make the state a leader in the energy sector.

The event also marked the inauguration and foundation laying of several projects in Khairthal-Tijara district, including the Elsin Electronics Complex and a 34 MLD sewage treatment plant, according to a release.

Union ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw and Bhupender Yadav also attended the programme virtually.

Vaishnaw said semiconductor manufacturing had emerged as a critical industry for India and that the country now had 12 semiconductor plants producing chips for various devices.

“Electronics manufacturing in India has increased six-fold over the last 12 years to ₹13 lakh crore, and mobile phones have become the country’s top export commodity,” Vaishnaw said.

He said the Bhiwadi electronics manufacturing cluster involved an investment of ₹1,200 crore and was expected to generate employment for around 2,500 people.



Gujarat pushes Vehicle Free Day to promote fuel conservation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Gandhinagar

The Gujarat Government has initiated steps to promote fuel conservation and sustainable transport practices by encouraging a weekly “Motor Vehicle-Free Day” across Government offices in the State.

According to official communication issued by Governor Acharya Devvrat, district collectors and municipal commissioners have been urged to encourage Government employees to adopt carpooling, use public transport and reduce dependence on private vehicles.

The move follows Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s recent appeal for fuel conservation amid rising expenditure on imported petroleum products. Ahead of a recent Cabinet meeting in Gandhinagar, several ministers reportedly arrived at the Secretariat using electric vehicles and shared transportation arrangements as part of the initiative.

In a letter addressed to administrative officials, the Governor highlighted the importance of reducing fuel



Governor Acharya Devvrat

consumption to minimise pressure on the economy and promote environmental awareness among citizens, especially the youth. The communication also mentioned that staff members at Raj Bhavan have

resolved to dedicate one day every week to commuting by walking, cycling or public transport. Officials have additionally been encouraged to conduct meetings through video conferencing and promote shared vehicle usage to save fuel.

District administrations and municipal bodies have also reportedly been asked to submit monthly reports detailing fuel-saving measures undertaken in their respective jurisdictions.

Mandaviya reviews India’s CWG 2026 preparations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Ahmedabad

Union Youth Affairs and Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya chaired a high-level review meeting to assess India’s preparations for the 2026 Commonwealth Games (CWG) scheduled to be held in Glasgow, Scotland.

The meeting focused on strengthening coordination among stakeholders and enhancing support systems for Indian athletes preparing for the international sporting event.

Senior officials from the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, representatives of the Indian Olympic Association, including the Chef de Mission for CWG



2026, and officials from the Sports Authority of India participated in the discussions.

Key aspects such as operational planning, athlete training, logistics, welfare measures and coordination mechanisms were reviewed during the meeting. Mandaviya reiterated the

Government’s commitment to providing all possible support to Indian athletes to ensure strong performances at the Games.

Discussions also covered preparations for the closing ceremony of the 2026 Commonwealth Games, during which India is expected to officially receive the baton for hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games in Ahmedabad, Gujarat.

Representatives from the Gujarat Government, including Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi, also took part in the review meeting and discussed arrangements related to the proposed 2030 Games.

Officials further reviewed inter-ministerial coordination efforts concerning operational and logistical planning for Glasgow 2026. Authorities shared updates on training schedules, deployment of support staff, athlete engagement programmes and contingency planning for the Indian contingent.

Reserved category candidates barred from open seats in Maharashtra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Cabinet has approved a policy that candidates from reserved categories, who avail concessions in competitive examinations such as age relaxation and educational qualification, will not be eligible to claim appointment against open category posts. The decision was taken at

the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday, a statement issued by the General Administration Department said.

However, the Congress alleged that the move shows the “hidden agenda to dilute reservation”, and claimed that the decision was part of a systematic attempt to weaken reservation through indirect means.



The Government said the policy would bring greater

clarity regarding the selection of candidates from

reserved categories on merit in the open category and ensure more transparency and consistency in the implementation of reservation.

Under the policy, reserved category candidates who have not availed any concession at any stage of the recruitment process in terms of age, educational qualification, experience or number of attempts allowed in examinations — excluding exam-

ination fee concessions — will be eligible for selection in the open category on the basis of merit.

However, candidates from reserved categories who have availed any relaxation provided by the Government in age, educational qualification, experience or number of examination attempts will continue to be counted against their respective reserved category quotas.

AIADMK factions hold discussions, no solution yet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Chennai

As the internal rift continues within the AIADMK, party general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami met the new district secretaries at his residence on Friday to discuss the future course of action, even as the rebel group led by SP Velumani and CV Shanmugam also organised a meeting to consider the possibility of moving the court to find a solution.

The AIADMK chief had removed from party posts, senior leaders including Velumani, Shanmugam and C Vijayabaskar in the wake of the rift and cross-voting in the TVK Government’s con-



AIADMK, party general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami

fidence vote on Wednesday, which the ruling party won comfortably.

At present, Palaniswami has the support of 22 MLAs, while the rebel faction led by Velumani and Shanmugam is backed by 25 AIADMK leg-

islators. Both factions have sought disqualification against the other’s MLAs under the anti-defection law over voting during the TVK Government’s floor test.

Sources said that during his meeting with supporters,

Palaniswami expressed concern that the Assembly Speaker had yet to announce their elected leader of the legislature party, his deputy and whip.

The former Chief Minister also asked the party cadres, especially the new district secretaries, to stay united to counter the Shanmugam faction.

Valumani’s group also said that since the faction has the majority of MLAs, the team is working out to legally “secure” the AIADMK.

Both AIADMK factions have already met the assembly speaker JCD Prabhakar to declare their respective choice of leader of the legislator party, his deputy and whip.

However, sources from the Secretariat said that the speaker was looking into their request and would decide soon.

Meanwhile, the party’s Laigudi constituency MLA and a part of the Velumani group, Leema Rose Martin, said that there will be a united AIADMK. “Measures are being taken. Soon we will join”.

Former AIADMK minister and senior party leader KC Veeramani said that the party should immediately convene a general council meeting and find out a solution for the poll debacle.

He also stressed that Palaniswami is the party general secretary and “we all stand with him”.

DNA matching solves woman’s murder mystery

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dehradun

A months-long mystery surrounding skeletal remains recovered from Uttar Pradesh’s Hathnikund Barrage has finally been solved, with DNA matching confirming that the victim was a 22-year-old Uttarakhand woman, who had gone missing last year and was allegedly murdered by a man who was “harassing” her.

The breakthrough came after forensic experts matched the skeletal remains with Riya Kashyap, a resident of the Jeevagarh area in Dehradun’s Vikasnagar, bringing closure to a case that had remained unresolved for months. According to police,



a woman’s torso was recovered from the Hathnikund Barrage on October 16, 2025. However, due to the highly decomposed condition of the body, investigators were unable to establish the victim’s identity at the time.

Kashyap had been missing since September 2025. Her father, Gopal, lodged a complaint on September 7, alleging that Shahbaz, a resident of Dhakrani village, had kidnapped his daughter.

He claimed the accused had been harassing her and was responsible for her disappearance.

A case under Section 140(1) (kidnapping) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) was registered and an investigation launched.

The police said analysis of Call Detail Records (CDR) and CCTV footage led investigators to Shahbaz, who was later arrested. During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed to the crime and admitted that he knew Kashyap.

Shahbaz told police that he lured the woman to the Kulhal area with the intention of killing her after she refused to have physical relations with him.

Editor's
TAKE

BRICS at Delhi: Voice of the Global South

BRICS has emerged as a stronger political voice demanding strategic autonomy and fairer economic. But its real test lies in overcoming internal divisions

As the members of the BRICS nations meet in Delhi, the unease is visible. The founding members – Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa – represent over 40 per cent of the world's population, while the newly expanded BRICS+ alliance represents approximately 55.6 per cent of the global population. Most of these nations are emerging economies with fragile and vulnerable financial systems. That is the story of the Global South continuously reeling under pressure and facing headwinds from the North, sometimes in the form of tariffs, environmental concerns, uncertainties in the energy market, or pressure to join one bloc or another.

The Delhi Summit is, therefore, not just a formal grouping but a cumulative effort to send a strong message to the West that it must consider the issues confronting these countries and not impose its agenda. BRICS is no longer merely an economic grouping. It was conceptualised in 2001 as an economic forum, and its first summit took place in 2009, but today it is a potent political force. Under India's chairmanship, it has emerged strongly and has been vocal about the issues it wants addressed by the developed nations.

From wars in West Asia and Ukraine to sanctions, energy insecurity and fractured supply chains, BRICS nations are advocating a just global governance system that gives them strategic autonomy and economic equity. The challenge, however, lies in transforming shared grievances into a coherent and credible global agenda. The Delhi summit of the BRICS grouping comes at a moment of profound churn in international politics. The summit's agenda reflects the anxieties of a rapidly fragmenting world. India's External Affairs Minister, S Jaishankar, has sharply criticised unilateral sanctions and coercive measures, arguing that "pressure cannot replace diplomacy". His remarks are significant because they underscore India's attempt to maintain strategic autonomy while simultaneously positioning itself as a responsible voice for developing nations.

The BRICS nations are clamouring for reform of the UN Security Council, greater representation for emerging economies in global financial institutions, and protection of sovereign decision-making. Another major concern before the summit is the growing instability in West Asia. Tensions around the Strait of Hormuz have disrupted energy supplies. For developing economies heavily dependent on imported energy, these conflicts are direct economic threats. BRICS leaders are therefore advocating dialogue, ceasefires and diplomatic engagement in conflict zones. However, BRICS is not a cohesive force. The grouping faces several internal challenges. India-China tensions continue to cast a shadow over cooperation, while Russia's direct confrontation with the West makes BRICS's task more difficult. Yet, despite these contradictions, BRICS remains relevant because it reflects a changing global reality.

The old unipolar order is weakening, but a stable multipolar system has not yet emerged. BRICS's credibility will depend on whether it can move beyond rhetoric and remain cohesive so that it can voice its concerns collectively. It must first demonstrate that its diversity is its strength, not its weakness.

Bengal's verdict against the 'Kabuliwala trap'

West Bengal's verdict is more than an electoral transition; it is a correction. The people have not merely voted out a government, but rejected a political culture that romanticised disorder, normalised impunity, and mistook excessive empathy for moral virtue



ABHINAV WALIA

West Bengal has voted: voted with determination, courage, clarity and finality. In that unmistakable vote lies not merely a political verdict, but a psychological one. The people of Bengal did not simply change a government; they actually repudiated a culture – a culture of decades-long accommodation of lawlessness dressed in the language of compassion, a governance model that protected the predator while rendering the victim invisible.

The new administration inherits both an opportunity and an obligation. What it does next will determine whether Bengal's mandate becomes a turning point or merely an interlude.

Every society carries within it a set of assumptions about crime and punishment; assumptions so deeply embedded that they feel like common sense rather than ideology. In Bengal, that embedded assumption has been what evolutionary thinker Gad Saad might call "suicidal empathy": the systematic prioritisation of empathy for the perpetrator of crime over security for the innocent. It sounds compassionate, but in practice, it is catastrophic.

When empathy becomes reflexive rather than reasoned, when it flows automatically towards the offender and away from the victim, it ceases to be a virtue and becomes what Saad terms an "idea pathogen": a belief system that corrodes a society's rational defences from within and becomes a "psychological trap". A society that mistakes tolerance for criminals as virtue does not grow more humane, but more vulnerable.

Bengal's literary tradition is magnificent. Kabuliwala is a masterpiece of humanist writing – a story that finds paternal tenderness in an unlikely place and asks us to see the full human being behind the frightening exterior. As literature, it is irreplaceable, but as policy, it is lethal.

The Bhadrakol tradition is one of the sub-continent's finest civilisational achievements: cultivated, empathetic, and genuinely humane. It is precisely because of its nobility that it has proven so vulnerable to exploitation – where the stabbing of a neighbour becomes a tragic misunderstanding, where the recidivist becomes a victim of circumstance, and where the actual victim, who could be bleeding, frightened, or even



BENGAL'S VOTERS DID NOT QUEUE IN THE SUMMER HEAT TO BE GIVEN MORE POETRY. THEY CAME FOR SOMETHING OLDER, SIMPLER AND MORE URGENT: THE RIGHT TO WALK HOME SAFELY, TO SLEEP WITHOUT FEAR, AND TO RAISE CHILDREN IN A STATE THAT PROTECTS RATHER THAN POETICISES

The writer is a former Additional Secretary, Ministry of Communications, Government of India

 dailypioneer
 @TheDailyPioneer
 dr-abhinav-walia-6193a034

silenced, becomes an afterthought in the moral drama centred on the perpetrator.

This is not compassion. This is "pathological altruism", a concept studied seriously in behavioural psychology, where the very impulse to protect becomes the instrument of harm. The new government in Bengal needs to come out of this "Kabuliwala trap".

The new government need not theorise because evidence prevails regarding what really works in day-to-day administration, and this applies to the international canvas as well.

In early 2026, the Philippines implemented its intensified Safer Cities initiative by prioritising high-visibility policing and swift accountability. This resulted in a marked decrease in serious crime.

Singapore implemented a civilisational model based on the same principle: the rule of law, applied consistently and without sentiment, is the most compassionate gift a government can give its people. Today, it is one of the world's safest and most prosperous societies.

Then there is New York City. Within living memory, Times Square was not a destination; it was a no-go zone. Crime was not an occasional visitor; it was a permanent resident. When the administration prioritised safety, the murder rate fell, the streets returned to their people, and tourism soared. All in all, New York did not become cruel; instead, it became safe.

The upshot is that safety is not a cultural inheritance, but a policy choice.

Bengal has seen its own version of this paralysis. The new government must name it, reject it, and replace it. What Bengal needs is not harshness, but clarity, especially "rational realism": the struggling background of a perpetrator explains his history, but it does not excuse his violence. Human rights protections exist to shield the innocent, not to provide legal sanctuary for the predator. Swift, certain and visible consequences for

crime are not barbarism. They are the highest form of social compassion and a declaration that the law-abiding citizen's right to live without fear matters more than the criminal's right to exploit it.

The new government in Bengal needs, on the one hand, to de-romanticise crime and, on the other, to institutionalise victim-centric justice, thereby restoring the "social contract".

Bengal's voters did not queue in the summer heat to be given more poetry. They came for something older, simpler and more urgent: the right to walk home safely, to sleep without fear, and to raise children in a state that protects rather than poeticises.

To govern is to choose, and the choice before this administration is not between compassion and cruelty; it is between empathy that protects the innocent and empathy that, through its own excess, destroys them.

Bengal's populace has chosen, and governance should now become the echo of that choice.

PIC TALK



A herder with his cattle walk on a dried up land near the Bilawali Pond on a hot summer day, in Indore, Madhya Pradesh.

PHOTO: PTI



ASHA IYER KUMAR

2ND OPINION

Artificial intelligence is no longer confined to the edges of innovation; it is steadily becoming part of the everyday rhythm of education. Its presence in school curricula is not loud or disruptive, but quietly influential, shaping how students engage with learning and how educators respond to their needs.

Not only are we seeing new tools; we are also seeing an entirely different experience created through this evolution. The advent of AI has opened up ways to support not only students' academic growth, but also the confidence and well-being that sit at the heart of meaningful learning.

For years, the classroom has been built on a straightforward approach of one teacher, one lesson, one pace. But all learners are different, some move ahead

quickly, while others need more time. AI is starting to close this gap by figuring out when a student is having trouble or is ready to move on, which lets learning adapt to each person's needs. It also changes what teachers do by taking over tasks like grading and keeping track of progress. As classrooms evolve, teachers act as guides and mentors who assist students in interpreting the material rather than instructing them. At the same time, learning remains deeply tied to confidence, motivation, and self-worth. In this context, AI can contribute positively to this system. If implemented correctly, it can facilitate learning through timely feedback, personalized instructions, and early detection of disinterest, among other ways. It can support both performance and well-being. Nonetheless, the story has another side to it?

The fear is that students will reach for AI and thoughtlessly use it as a shortcut, skipping the thinking and questioning that leads to learning? Therefore, schools should teach students how to use AI rather than how to access it, with the goal of turning out critical thinkers rather than efficient problem solvers?

Then there are questions of ethics, which are becoming increasingly important?

How else is student data being used?

Are these systems fair for all learners? Are we teaching children how to use technology? These are not technical questions alone, they're deeply human ones. And they must be part of the conversation in every school that chooses to embrace AI.

The real impact lies in how thoughtfully schools integrate AI. The priority should be on building AI literacy rather than simply teaching its usage, while ensuring that teachers are equipped and trained alongside students.

Education has never been just about facts. At its heart, education is an experience rooted in relationship-building and mentorship. AI cannot replace that, and it shouldn't try to. What it can do is strengthen it.

When AI is used in the classroom in a thoughtful way, it can make learning spaces more flexible and welcoming to all students, recognising and accepting the different experiences of each one. It gives teachers more time to help students become more curious, confident, and able to express themselves. Maybe this is the real power of AI in the classroom: making it truly inclusive to everyone.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist, independent journalist and children's writing coach

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

 www.dailypioneer.com

 facebook.com/dailypioneer  [@TheDailyPioneer](https://twitter.com/TheDailyPioneer)

 instagram.com/dailypioneer  linkedin.com/in/ThePioneer

HYDROGEN BUSES MARK SHIFT TOWARDS GREEN URBAN TRANSPORT

This refers to "Metro to launch hydrogen-powered buses in Central Vista area" (May 15). The move marks a significant step towards cleaner and more sustainable urban mobility. Hydrogen fuel offers several advantages, including zero tailpipe carbon emissions, quieter operation, and faster refuelling compared to battery-electric buses. It can also reduce India's dependence on imported crude oil and strongly supports the country's National Green Hydrogen Mission.

However, several challenges and safety concerns remain. Hydrogen is highly flammable and requires storage under extremely high pressure or at cryogenic temperatures. The country presently lacks adequate hydrogen refuelling infrastructure, while accidental leaks could pose safety risks. Therefore, strict

safety measures such as leak-detection systems, proper ventilation, and fire-resistant materials are essential to build public confidence.

The economic aspect is equally important. According to NITI Aayog, green hydrogen produced through electrolysis currently costs around ₹500-600 per kilogram, making it far more expensive than conventional fuels. At present, operating a hydrogen-powered bus costs nearly twice as much as running a diesel bus.

Despite these hurdles, hydrogen-powered buses represent a futuristic and environmentally responsible transport solution. Their long-term success will depend upon reducing production costs, expanding infrastructure, and ensuring uncompromising safety standards.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The compulsion to raise oil prices

This refers to the news report, "Petrol, diesel prices hiked by ₹3 across India" (May 15). One commendable aspect of the Modi Government's tenure has been its restraint in increasing fuel prices since 2022. However, amid the ongoing tensions and conflict in West Asia, crude oil prices have risen sharply in the international market. The current increase in fuel prices is not due to India's policies, but rather the instability created by oil-producing and conflict-ridden regions, which has disrupted global energy markets.

Major public sector oil companies such as Indian Oil Corporation, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited must balance international demand, supply and trade realities while determining domestic fuel prices.

Sustaining prolonged losses would adversely affect both the national economy and the finances of individual States.

In these circumstances, the Government has been compelled to raise petrol and diesel prices by ₹3.25 per litre. However, rising inflation will inevitably burden common citizens. People should therefore increasingly adopt alternatives such as carpooling and greater use of public transport.

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

Colonial shadow over TN

Go and look at the Speaker's Chair inside the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly. There is an inscription on it: "Gifted by Lord Willingdon, Governor of Madras Presidency, and Lady Willingdon on March 6, 1922." That chair has remained inside the Tamil Nadu Assembly for 103 years.

Congress sat in it. DMK sat in it. AIADMK sat in it. TVK sits in it. Every single MLA who rises to speak addresses that chair. Every word spoken in that House is directed towards a colonial gift.

Not one government in 78 years of Independence thought to change it. Not one Speaker raised the question. This is institutional inertia married to psychological colonisation. The British left the building, but never left the mind.

Now look at the new Tamil Nadu Chief Minister as temperatures touch 45 degrees. He walked into the Assembly in a black suit, white shirt and black trousers - the full colonial uniform. The veshti, the traditional attire symbolising Tamil identity and dignity, was absent. A leader's words are theatre; his choices are autobiography.

Seventy-eight years after Independence, much still remains unchanged.

SHANTHI RAMANATH | CHENNAI

Steadfast approach for women's rights

In Indian tradition, women have long been regarded as the foundation of Shakti, creation and leadership. Today, this philosophy has increasingly taken the shape of concrete policy, wherein women are viewed not merely as beneficiaries, but as the vanguard of development.

In recent years, it has become evident that when provided access to opportunities, resources and participation in decision-making, women scale new heights in every sphere. From the armed forces to start-ups, and from sports to science and research, the daughters of our nation are creating new milestones through their talent and perseverance.

This transformation is not merely symbolic, but the direct outcome of policy priorities that have placed women's participation and leadership at their core. The effort to translate women's reservation into reality is also an integral part of this broader vision. Despite not receiving the required support in Parliament, the Government of India remains steadfast in its commitment to securing women their rightful entitlements.

However, rights must go beyond policy and legal guarantees. Self-respect and dignity for women should remain the foremost priority of society.

JAYANTHY S MANIAM | COIMBATORE

From whistles to whispers!

The responsibility before the new government led by actor-turned-politician Vijay



RAVIKUMAR CHOCKALINGAM

As the newly formed government led by actor-turned-politician Vijay begins its tenure, Tamil Nadu faces a test greater than an electoral upset. The real question is whether a politics built on adoration can mature into one grounded in fiscal discipline, social repair, public safety and long-term development.

Tamil Nadu enters this new chapter with enormous strengths, but also with visible fatigue. For decades, the state has been shaped by parties that built enduring welfare legacies yet gradually allowed those achievements to harden into entitlement politics, fiscal strain and a culture of reduced accountability. That accumulated exhaustion created the opening for a new force to disrupt a deeply entrenched establishment.

The rise of a new government led by actor-turned-politician Vijay is therefore not merely a story of celebrity crossing into politics. It is also a reflection of public impatience with an old order that had grown too comfortable with habit, symbolism and transactional politics. When people begin to feel that governments can distribute benefits but not renew trust, disruption stops looking risky and becomes necessary. Yet electoral change by itself is not democratic fulfilment. It is only the beginning of a more serious obligation. A government formed on the strength of public enthusiasm must now show that it can govern with restraint, competence and moral clarity. The whistles of victory are fleeting and cannot overshadow the burden of power and the enormous responsibility that comes with it. That burden is heavier when the margins are narrow. A slim majority is still a valid democratic mandate, but it is also a reminder that nearly half the political community may remain unconvinced, anxious or opposed. In such a moment, triumphalism is dangerous. The new government must treat victory not as a license for excess, but as a call for humility, consultation and steady administration. It must listen more carefully, govern more inclusively and avoid the temptation to confuse electoral arithmetic with moral unanimity.

A peaceful transition of power matters so deeply. In every healthy democracy, the transfer of authority must be orderly, dignified and free from vendetta, instability or street-level intimidation. The maturity of a democratic culture is tested not only in the casting of votes, but in the conduct that follows the verdict. The chosen leader leads everyone, more so the ones who did not vote in favor. This is especially important in Tamil Nadu, a state with a strong political memory and an emotionally charged public sphere. Cadres who were trained in loyalty and mobilisation must now learn the harder discipline of democratic responsibility.

The failures of earlier governments must also teach lessons for future. The establishment did not fail because it did nothing. It failed because it increasingly blurred the line between welfare and dependency, governance and patronage, compassion and convenience. For too long, elections risked becoming contests of distribution rather than contests of vision. That approach may produce applause, but it also deepens fiscal pressure and weakens the culture of citizenship. A state cannot indefinitely promise more, borrow more and postpone structural correction without eventually narrowing its future choices.

The contradiction is perhaps sharpest in the social sphere. Governments spoke the language of family welfare while remaining comfortable with revenue models and public conditions that often contributed to social distress. They announced safety, but too many women still experienced fear in transit and indifference in systems meant to protect them. They celebrated youth, but too often failed to build clear bridges from education to dignity, work and civic belonging.

This is where the new government will be tested. It must prove that change means more than a change of face. It must show that governance can move from spectacle to seriousness, from distribution to capability, from patronage to public purpose. That requires political courage, the courage to speak honestly about debt, to reform without cruelty, to protect the vulnerable without manufacturing dependency and to invest in long-term systems rather than short-term applause. If this means, revisiting promises surrounding freebies and focusing on stronger fiscally responsible welfare schemes, people will understand with reason. Freebies are defensible during floods, droughts and pandemics. They are an ethical response to sudden vulnerability.



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

HE WHISTLES ARE LOUD TODAY. BUT WHEN THEY FADE, WHAT MUST REMAIN IS THE ABILITY TO HEAR THE WHISPERS, THE ANXIETIES OF FAMILIES, THE FEARS OF WOMEN, THE FRUSTRATION OF YOUTH, THE BURDENS OF WORKERS AND THE QUIET EXPECTATIONS OF THOSE WHOSE FAITH IN DEMOCRACY RESTS NOT ON RHETORIC, BUT ON RESULTS

The writer is MD MPH, Psychiatrist and Public Health Scholar, US Department of Veterans Affairs

 dailypioneer

 @TheDailyPioneer

 ravikumar-chockalingam-md-mp-h-54b60724

But when they become the central grammar of governance, they risk turning relief into dependency and citizenship into clientele. A good government does not merely distribute. It enables. It teaches people how to fish rather than ensuring they remain in line for the next packet of food.

As a psychiatrist working in addition, I have witnessed the far-reaching consequences of drug and alcohol use on individuals and families. It is imperative for governments to recognize the pervasive impact of Drug and alcohol use on the welfare of families and wellbeing of young adults. It is a force multiplier of poverty, domestic violence, school dropout, depression, accidents and lost labor productivity. A state cannot claim to protect families while growing comfortable with revenue streams that help break them. Nor can it address narcotics and synthetic drug use through police action alone. Tamil Nadu needs a public health led addiction policy, systematic de-addiction programs linked to government health systems, school-based prevention programs, stronger anti-trafficking enforcement and abolition of liquor availability around schools, colleges and labor settlements. This need not mean theatrical overnight prohibition. India's own history shows that abrupt prohibition without preparation can fuel bootlegging and illicit harm. But a phased path toward partial, and eventually wider, alcohol restriction linked to rehabilitation, alternative livelihoods and behavioral health would be a far more serious legacy than allowing the state to remain dependent on intoxication for revenue.

Tamil Nadu does not also need endless emotional mobilization. There is a rich legacy of social and economic development, thanks to progressive policies of previous governments going back decades. However, populism expanded faster than reform, political theatre often outran institutional repair and the difficult work of preparing Tamil Nadu for its next stage of development was repeatedly postponed. Today, it needs administrative depth. It needs safer streets, stronger schools, better public transport, genuine women's safety, economic opportunity for youth and a fiscal framework that does not mortgage the future to sustain the present. Tamil Nadu already has a formal women's policy focused on violence-free homes, safe mobility, equal wages and economic access, and the TNWESafe programme seeks to link women's employment, safety and health through a large-scale policy platform, but policy architecture alone is not enough. The real test is whether a schoolgirl can commute safely, whether a working woman can return home without fear, and whether survivors encounter dignity rather than indifference in police stations and hospitals. Tamil Nadu can well be in the race to become the safest state in India to be a girl. That would require measurable district-wise scorecards on crimes against women and children, better street lighting, safer transport, fast-tracked investigations, one-stop crisis support, and stronger integration of schooling, social welfare and mental health systems.

The new government also calls for transcendence from rulers and supporters. Fans have become cadres, and it's time for them to become model citizens. Citizens must insist that leadership be judged not by charisma, mythology or emotional loyalty, but by outcomes, whether families feel safer, whether public money is spent more wisely, whether institutions become fairer and whether opportunity reaches those who stand far from the stage.

The whistles are loud today. But when they fade, what must remain is the ability to hear the whispers, the anxieties of families, the fears of women, the frustration of youth, the burdens of workers and the quiet expectations of those whose faith in democracy rests not on rhetoric, but on results. A new generation of politicians may have earned this moment, but they have very little time to grow into power, for the consequences of inexperience in public office are measured not in headlines, but in human lives.

Sanatan: Tradition loudly possessed, quietly unread



ACHARYA PRASHANT

The word "Sanatan" means eternal. It is now among the most fiercely contested words in Indian public life, invoked to denounce, defend and mobilise, with an urgency that might suggest the arguers possess some acquaintance with the tradition the word names. The urgency disguises a near-universal absence of that acquaintance. Its label is loudly possessed, while its philosophical core is quietly unread. A label offers identity without the cost of inquiry; the tradition's core offers inquiry without the comfort of a pre-settled identity.

When Udhayanidhi Stalin declared that Sanatan Dharma was like dengue and malaria, to be eradicated and not merely opposed, the response unfolded with perfect predictability. Critics attacked a version of Sanatan Dharma that bears little resemblance to what the term philosophically denotes. Defenders rushed to protect a version they have largely never read. The actual philosophical tradition sat untouched by either side, as irrelevant to the noise as a library to a riot outside its doors.

The critics have genuine grievances. Caste discrimination, patriarchy and the ritual exploitation of the vulnerable are real, documented and still operative. Periyar E. V. Ramasamy's long campaign against them represents one of modern India's more serious engagements with social oppression. The criticism arises from lived experience. Warranted indignation, however, is not the same as accurate targeting. The social evils that animated Periyar did not arise from the philosophical core of Sanatan Dharma. They arose from the ego's capacity to commandeer any available language in service of exploitation. The exploiter and the tradition the exploiter has hijacked are not the same thing. The social evils were committed in its name, not in its spirit; to discard the tradition on this basis is to throw away the antidote because the poison was administered in the same bottle.

What does Sanatan Dharma actually mean? The root "dharma" denotes the fundamental obligation one owes to one's own existence. "Sanatan" denotes that which holds true irrespective of time, place or circumstance. What qualifies as eternal in this sense? Ritual varies by village, belief by century, and custom by caste and region - all contingent. What remains constant across all times, geographies, genders and religious affiliations is the inner human condition: restlessness, fear, bondage to desire, and the persistent sense that something essential is missing. This condition belongs, as the tradition diagnoses, to the structure of the ego that has not yet turned to examine itself. The dharma that arises from this eternal condition is equally universal: to move, through honest inquiry, from bondage towards understanding. It is not a religion in the conventional sense, but a description of the ego's most fundamental predicament and of what it owes itself in response.

The tradition distinguishes sharply between Shruti — the Vedas and Upanishads — and Smriti, which includes the Manusmriti and the Puranas. The texts containing caste hierarchies and patriarchal injunctions belong overwhelmingly to the Smriti category, composed between one thousand and fifteen hundred years ago, far more recent than the Vedic core they claim to elaborate. Sanatan Dharma, properly understood, is Vedantic. The lived tradition did not consistently honour this hierarchy. Yet the canonical core's method — inquiry rather than acceptance — dissolves caste readings on the tradition's own terms. The Vajrasuchi Upanishad makes this explicit: caste belongs only to the ego, which is to say it is the ego's construction, not a feature of any reality the ego did not itself produce.

Three categorically distinct things are routinely conflated. Sanatan Dharma is a philosophical orientation directed towards liberation from inner bondage, indifferent to creed and community. Hinduism, as the Supreme Court of India has rightly observed, is a vast and internally inconsistent collection of belief systems held together largely by geographical provenance. Hindutva is a political ideology, barely a century old, that seeks to define national identity through cultural markers whose roots lie largely in the Mughal and British periods. When critics attack Sanatan Dharma and mean practised Hinduism, they target a real problem under the wrong name. When defenders protect Sanatan Dharma and mean Hindutva, they mount a real defence of the wrong object.

The central word of Sanatan Dharma is not belief but jigyaasa — the hunger to know. The tradition tells the seeker that received beliefs, accumulated from family, culture and community, are themselves the primary obstacle to liberation. A true Sanatani is not someone who believes more intensely; he is someone who examines his own beliefs more rigorously than anyone else's. By the criterion the tradition itself provides, a Muslim who sincerely inquires into the nature of his own inner bondage qualifies as a Sanatani under the tradition's own definition. Conversely, the person who recites mantras without inquiry and wears religious identity as scaffolding for the ego does not qualify, regardless of the label claimed.

The most pointed irony of this controversy is that Periyar, the figure critics invoke, was animated throughout his life by a refusal to accept received authority, a rage against exploitation disguised in sacred language, and a commitment to rational inquiry over hereditary belief. Within the framework of Sanatan Dharma properly understood, this disposition is not antithetical to the tradition; it is, in the most precise sense, the tradition itself. Annihilation of Caste is not a rejection of inquiry; it is a sustained accusation that the practised tradition refused to apply inquiry to itself. BR Ambedkar was operating against its institutional capture, and that operation was itself an exercise of the method. The label belongs to the egos that fight over labels. The method remains available to anyone willing to undertake it.

Sanatan Dharma is among the most rigorous philosophical traditions humanity has produced. That its foundational texts now sit largely unread, while superstition and communal aggression are carried out in their name, is not the fault of the tradition. It is the fault of those who invoke its name while fleeing from its demands.

The question that should trouble everyone involved — defender and critic alike — is this: what exactly were you fighting over?



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

 @acharya_prashant_paf

 @Prashant_Advait

 prashantadvait

India asserts its maritime power to ensure energy shipping



ANIL BHAT

Following a major escalation in the US-Iran conflict since February-March 2026, along with strict controls imposed by the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) in the Strait of Hormuz, the Indian Navy, under Operation Urga Suraksha (energy protection), began maintaining a high-alert deployment in the Gulf of Oman and the northern Arabian Sea to secure Indian commercial shipping passing through the vicinity of the Strait of Hormuz.

While Iran's theocratic leadership has maintained relations with India based on historic ties and a strategic partnership centred around the development of Chabahar Port, the IRGC has pursued its own agenda, which has included targeting Indian or India-bound merchant ships and tankers — perhaps not every time, but often enough. On December 8, 2025, the IRGC forcefully detained 16 Indian crew members aboard the merchant tanker MT Valiant Roar in the Gulf over alleged fuel smuggling. While ten of these sailors were initially moved to a prison in Bandar Abbas, the eight who remained on board were subsequently released in February 2026. By early 2026, 348 other Indian citizens from Iran had also returned home.

All this and more has been coordinated by India's Ministries of External Affairs (MEA), Ports, Shipping

and Waterways (MoPSW), through the Directorate of Shipping (DGS), Defence (MoD), Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), Information and Broadcasting (MIB), Indian missions in the region and, on the waters, a powerful flotilla of the Indian Navy.

By March 20, 2026, the IRGC had established a designated "safe corridor" closer to the Iranian coastline and warned against any deviation. Indian officials coordinated with regional authorities to facilitate the passage of Indian ships through this area. Despite a temporary and fragile ceasefire in early April, the area remained a high-risk zone, partly owing to reports of unrecorded mines laid by the IRGC and its offensive actions, including firing at ships, thereby necessitating close-protection escorts for critical fuel imports.

Following an incident on April 18, 2026, when IRGC personnel fired upon two Indian-linked vessels, India summoned the Iranian envoy in New Delhi on the same day to demand safe and uninterrupted passage for Indian ships. Iran maintained that "Indian friends" were in safe hands, even while conducting strict monitoring and allowing only selected vessels to pass.

The Indian Navy significantly enhanced its maritime posture by deploying two aircraft carrier battle groups, led by INS Vikrant and INS Vikramaditya. Operating together in the Persian Gulf, they amounted to a formidable force for sea control, with over 35 aircraft, numerous warships and submarines, thereby highlighting India's commitment to security in the Indian Ocean region,



clearly projecting power and strengthening maritime diplomacy.

This move, combined with New Delhi's high-level diplomatic pressure on Iran, proved effective against the IRGC and resulted in Indian-flagged vessels being allowed passage through the highly volatile region where shipping from other nations faced severe restrictions. In early May 2026, the Indian Government decisively asserted maritime rights and informed Tehran that no special permission or "protection fees" were required for Indian vessels, which would move under active guidance from the Indian Navy. A significant outcome of these actions was that over 14 (another version places the figure at 22) India-bound ships carrying energy cargo were escorted through the Strait of Hormuz with the assistance of the Indian Navy.

The Indian Navy has reportedly received praise for its effective, independent and proactive security operations, as well as for being a rapid-response security provider in the Indian Ocean Region. By successfully tackling piracy and maritime threats — such as the MV Lila Norfolk, FV Al Naeemi, FV Iman (all in January 2024), and the MV Ruen hijacking in

March 2024, to name a few — while utilising advanced surveillance and ensuring open, rules-based sea lanes, the Indian Navy has come to be recognised as a force that guarantees stability and safeguards regional interests. Its task forces continue securing Sea Lanes of Communication (SLOCs) and conducting daring rescue missions for commercial vessels targeted in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden. By hosting the International Fleet Review (IFR) 2026 in February, India showcased its growing indigenous shipbuilding capabilities and strong international partnerships, with participation from 75 nations, making it one of the largest maritime engagements in the region. Also in February, the Indian Navy assumed command of the 47-nation Combined Task Force 154 to focus on training and maritime security — an indicator of growing trust in India's professional expertise.

India has also increasingly come to be viewed as a nation that maintains its security role independently rather than formally joining US-led coalitions, a significant aspect of its foreign policy. The US Navy, on the other hand, has reportedly faced operational challenges in the Red Sea. One major report indicated that the USS Harry S. Truman carrier strike group encountered significant difficulties during its deployment there. Reports also cited multiple F/A-18 Super Hornets lost in 2025-26, with some incidents involving jets going overboard due to failed landings and hangar accidents. These losses occurred during a high-tempo campaign against Houthi forces in Yemen. Investigations into these incidents reportedly

pointed towards training gaps, equipment failures and intense operational pressure.

On April 9, 2026, the US Navy confirmed that a highly advanced and expensive MQ-4C Triton high-altitude, long-endurance (HALE) surveillance drone had been lost over the Persian Gulf. Each unit is estimated to cost between \$200 million and \$240 million. The drone disappeared near the Strait of Hormuz after sending an in-flight emergency signal. The US Naval Safety Command classified the incident as a "Class A mishap", indicating that the drone was destroyed and that the loss exceeded \$2.5 million.

The incident occurred amid rising tensions in the region involving Iran. While some reports speculated about possible interception or electronic warfare interference, official reports at the time stated that the drone had "crashed", with no injuries to personnel. This was the first known operational loss of an MQ-4C Triton, considered a major financial and strategic setback, as only about 20 of these drones were reportedly in service as of 2025. The incident followed a series of reported drone losses in the region, bringing the total value of lost or damaged aerial assets to over \$700 million at the time. Despite such massive losses and the suffering of millions of innocent people, the US President appears to have no plans for peace.

The writer is a VSM (Retd), a strategic affairs analyst and former spokesperson, Defence Ministry and Indian Army

 @dailypioneer

 @TheDailyPioneer

 The Pioneer



**TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS**

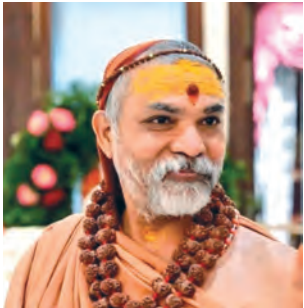
Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

HC rejects contempt against Swami Avimukteshwaranand

The Allahabad High Court on Friday rejected the contempt application filed against Swami Avimukteshwaranand Saraswati and his disciple Mukundanand Brahmachari, seeking punitive action over alleged disobedience of court order. Ashutosh Brahmachari Maharaj had filed the petition alleging violation of court order passed while granting anticipatory bail to Avimukteshwaranand in a POCSO case registered at Prayagraj. Rejecting the application, Justice Dinesh Pathak observed that the applicant could file for cancellation of anticipatory bail granted by the court, if he is violating bail conditions.



In the contempt application it was alleged that in spite of the order of High Court, Avimukteshwaranand is holding several meetings and is making statements in violation of High Court order. Earlier, Justice Rohit Ranjan Agarwal had recused himself from hearing the contempt petition saying that he does not want to hear the matter. After this, the chief justice nominated Justice Pathak to hear the matter. (PTI)

Bail to group of men held over Ganga iftar row

The Allahabad High Court on Friday granted bail to a group of men accused of consuming non-vegetarian food during an iftar party on a boat in the Ganga in Varanasi and throwing the leftover waste into the river. Justice Rajiv Lochan Shukla passed the order while hearing the bail application filed by the accused, and fixed May 18 for hearing the pleas of some other accused in the case.



Earlier, the High Court had granted one week time to the state Government's counsel to file a counter affidavit. In the bail application, the counsel for the accused claimed that his clients were falsely implicated in the case, and that they were not named in the FIR. The FIR was lodged on March 16 based on a complaint filed by Rajat Jaiswal, the president of the Varanasi chapter of the BJP Yuva Morcha, claiming that the incident hurt the sentiments of the Hindus. According to the complaint, the accused broke their Ramzan fast on a boat in the Ganga on March 15, ate meat, and threw the leftover waste into the "holy" river. (PTI)

Won't pass order in favour of mining lease holders for now, says SC on Aravalli row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday said it won't pass any order in favour of mining lease holders for now as it has been getting "quite disturbing" feedback regarding mining in the Aravalli hills and range.



The apex court said there were specific ecological issues and in February it had asked the environment ministry and other stakeholders to suggest names of domain experts for a panel to define the Aravalli hills and ranges.

"We will not hear this

matter in a piecemeal (manner). We will not permit any activity unless we are fully satisfied," a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi said after



NEET paper leak: Lokhande sent to 6-day CBI custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Friday sent NEET paper leak case accused Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande to six days' CBI custody, saying the agency needed to unearth the entire conspiracy, identify and arrest others, recover evidence and prevent tampering of evidence.

Special CBI judge Ajay Gupta was hearing the federal agency's plea seeking six days' custodial interrogation of Lokhande, who had been arrested from Ahilyanagar in Maharashtra, and brought to the court on a transit remand. "Allegedly, there is a larger conspiracy angle present in

this case; the investigation is at its very initial stage, and the custody of the accused Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande has been sought to unearth the entire conspiracy as well as arrest all the other active members of this organised paper leak gang and also for the recovery of all the relevant incriminating material," Judge Gupta said.

He noted that, according to Special Public Prosecutor Neetu Singh, Lokhande's custody was required to prevent further tampering with the evidence, as some of the accused persons had already deleted the incriminating data from their mobile phones.



"Therefore the CBI seeking six days' police custody remand of the accused is hereby allowed, and he is remanded to police custody for six days, subject to his

medical examination," the judge said.

Five more accused, Yash Yadav, Mangilal Khatik, Vikash Biwal, Dinesh Biwal and Shubham Khairnar, were

earlier remanded to CBI custody on Thursday till May 20. The court cited CBI's submission that the NEET 2026 exam was conducted on May 3, but before the scheduled date, a paper containing a substantial number of questions, which also appeared in the exam, was leaked and circulated in an organised manner for monetary gain.

It said that a fact-finding inquiry was conducted by the Special Operations Group (SOG), Rajasthan, which reportedly confirmed the authenticity of certain leaked questions.

"It has been submitted that until now, six accused persons, namely, Yash Yadav, Mangilal Khatik, Vikash Biwal,

Dinesh Biwal, Shubham Madhukar Khairnar and Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande, have been arrested and, allegedly, they are part of the organised gang who, in conspiracy with each other, leaked and circulated the confidential NEET examination paper 2026 for monetary gain," the court said.

On Lokhande's role, the court noted that according to the probe, he was known to Shubham.

It said that after receiving the material from another accused, he transmitted it to Shubham, and that there had been banking transactions of around ₹6 lakh between them.

Delhi court orders OpIndia to remove articles on journalist Swati Chaturvedi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court directed the website OpIndia to remove two articles, published around six years ago, about journalist Swati Chaturvedi, holding that the continued circulation of the pieces could cause "serious and irreparable injury" to her professional reputation while the defamation suit remains

shows" that Chaturvedi was involved in "running extortion rackets" as alleged in the impugned articles. Court observed that because Chaturvedi is a journalist and public commentator, her "professional reputation and credibility are of paramount importance."

"...The plaintiff shall suffer irreparable loss and injury in case the impugned articles



pending, Meenu Kaushik, district judge, Patiala House Court in an order dated May 13 noted that the "source articles" produced by the defendants did not prima facie support the claims made against Chaturvedi and accepted her argument that many allegedly defamatory statements could not be linked to material available in the public domain.

According to Chaturvedi, the articles described her as "delusional", accused her of plagiarism and fabrication, and alleged that she ran "extortion rackets".

The court made sharp observation regarding one of the most serious allegations. It said the material filed by OpIndia "prima facie nowhere

continued to be in public domain as the same may continue to cause harm to the reputation of the plaintiff." it said while directing OpIndia to remove/block the impugned articles during the pendency of the suit/till further orders.

In their defence, OpIndia had argued that any injunction would amount to a restriction on free speech and relied on legal precedents cautioning courts against prior restraint on media publications. However, the court held that temporarily taking down the articles would not prejudice the defendants because they remain free to establish the truth of their claims during trial. Journalist Chaturvedi is represented by advocate Akshat Gupta.

SC to hear cases online on Mondays, Fridays

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday decided to hear cases exclusively through video conference on Mondays and Fridays, and judges "unanimously resolved" to encourage car-pooling arrangements amongst themselves in order to ensure optimum fuel utilisation.

The move came following a call by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on cutting down avoidable expenditure due to the ongoing West Asia crisis.

"Matters listed on miscellaneous days (ie, on Mondays, Fridays, or such other days as declared to be

miscellaneous), and matters listed during the Court's partial working days, shall be heard by video-conferencing only.

"The Registry shall ensure that links for the video-conferencing are sent in a timely manner, stable video-conferencing facilities are maintained and timely technical assistance facilities are extended so as to avoid any inconvenience to the Hon'ble Court," a circular issued said.

The communication from the apex court also said that till further orders, up to 50 per cent of staff in each branch or section of the registry are permitted to work from home (WFH) for up to



two days every week, provided that the remaining staff remain available in the office to ensure uninterrupted functioning.

The Registrar concerned shall ensure that a weekly roster is prepared before

the commencement of the week. Staff who are permitted to work from home are directed to remain available on the telephone and be ready to attend office, in case of requirement, at any time.

HC seeks ED's reply on Al-Falah University chairman's bail plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday sought the stand of the Enforcement Directorate on a regular bail application by Al-Falah University group chairman Jawad Ahmed Siddiqui in a money laundering case.

Justice Saurabh Banerjee issued notice to the agency, asking it to file its response.

While the court listed the main bail plea for hearing in July, it said it would hear Siddiqui's plea for interim bail at the end of this month.

The trial court had rejected Siddiqui's bail application on May 2.

Siddiqui was arrested for his alleged involvement in a money laundering case



linked to the generation of illicit funds from the fees paid by students at his educational institution in Faridabad.

He was arrested on November 18, 2025 in the case registered by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

The ED probe in the case stems from two FIRs by the

Delhi Police Crime Branch alleging that Al Falah University falsely projected NAAC accreditation and UGC recognition to mislead students and parents.

The agency has alleged the university generated ₹415.10 crore between 2018 and 2025 and that funds collected from students were diverted for personal use.

Some unemployed 'youngsters like cockroaches' become media, activists; attack system, says CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Likening some unemployed youngsters to cockroaches, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Friday said they go on to "become" media, social media and RTI activists and start attacking the system.

The comments came while a bench of CJI Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi was pulling up a lawyer for "pursuing" a senior advocate designation. It said there were already "parasites" in society who attack the system and asked the petitioner whether he wanted to join hands with them.

"The entire world may be eligible to become senior (advocate), but at least



you are not entitled," the bench told the petitioner lawyer.

A visibly anguished CJI observed that if the Delhi High Court would confer senior advocate designation upon the petitioner, the apex court would

set that aside seeing his professional conduct. The CJI also referred to the kind of language used by the petitioner on Facebook.

"There are already parasites of society who attack the system and you want to join hands with them?" he said.

"There are youngsters like cockroaches, who don't get any employment or have any place in profession. Some of them become media, some of them become social media, RTI activists and other activists and they start attacking everyone," he said.

The bench also asked the petitioner whether he did not have any other litigation.

Uttarakhand Government's recommendation for premature release of convict Rohit Chaturvedi. The top court noted that Chaturvedi has spent 22 years in jail without remission.

"Crime is one thing, reformation is different. The focus of the State should be reformation, not retribution," the bench observed. The apex court noted that Chaturvedi is already out on bail and need not surrender. Shukla was shot dead on May 9, 2003, in Lucknow's Paper Mill Colony while she was pregnant.



SC seeks rationalisation of airfares, asks Centre to provide relief to people

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday said there should be some rationalisation of airfares and asked the Centre to provide relief to flyers.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta flagged that on the same day, one airline flying in the same sector charges a particular airfare while other charges a different airfare.

"Try to give some relief to the people because of the discrepancy. On the same day, flights to the same sector, one airline charges ₹8000 while the other airline charges ₹18000 for the economy class," the bench told Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre. Justice Mehta said, "There

should be some rationalisation (of airfares)" after the solicitor general said that a new enactment of 2024 has come into effect and the corresponding rules are in the process of consultation.

Mehta said the Government was not disputing the problem and is treating the issue as non-adversarial and considering all aspects.

The bench was hearing a plea filed by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector and regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India. Senior advocate Ravindra



Srivastava, appearing for Laxminarayanan submitted that rules are already there under the Aircraft Act of 1937 but the problem is that they were not followed.

Mehta agreed that old rules are in place but new ones being formulated under the Bharatiya Vyayyan Adhiniyam of 2024 that came into effect in January, 2025. Srivastava

said till the new rules are framed, the old rules will continue and it says that if the DGCA is satisfied that in a particular situation, the airlines are indulging in charging predatory or excessive fares, it will issue directions.

"They are not issuing any directions. The rules are there, the power is there but it is a case of non-exercise of

powers," he submitted. The bench asked Srivastava to reply to the counter-affidavit filed by the Centre and recorded the solicitor general's submission that consultation process for formulation of rules under the new regime is going on.

The bench posted the matter for hearing on July 13.

On April 30, the top court pulled up the Centre for not filing its affidavit on a petition which sought regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

It had asked the Centre to file an application along with an affidavit giving reasons for why the affidavit has not been filed and why further time was sought for it.

Unnao rape case: SC asks HC to decide Sengar plea afresh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday set aside a Delhi High Court order suspending the life sentence of former BJP MLA Kuldeep Singh Sengar in the 2017 Unnao rape case and asked it to decide the plea afresh.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi also asked the High Court to make endeavours to decide the main plea of Sengar against his conviction and life imprisonment in the case within two months.

It further said that if it was not possible for the High Court to decide the main



plea expeditiously, then it should pass an order on a plea of Sengar seeking the suspension of the life term in the case before the start of the summer vacation there.

The bench, which had earlier set aside the HC order granting bail to Sengar after a huge public uproar over the issue, said that it did not express any opinion on the merits of the case and the

High Court could proceed with it afresh.

The CJI also asked the HC to decide afresh issues like whether an MLA can be treated as a public servant for being prosecuted under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Earlier, the top court had deferred to the first week of May the hearing on a petition filed by the CBI challenging the suspension of life imprisonment of the former MLA in the rape case.

On December 29 last year, the top court stayed the Delhi High Court order suspending Sengar's life sentence and said he shall not be released from custody.

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

US team likely to visit India next month for trade talks

The US team is expected to visit India next month for trade talks, though no dates have been finalised yet, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Friday.

The Indian side visited Washington, DC, in April for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts to finalise the details of the interim pact and take forward the negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

“We expect the US team to visit soon... not this month... may be next month,” he told reporters here.

He said India is engaged with the US on trade deal and it would be signed at an opportune time.

He also said that India is engaged with the US on section 301 investigations.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for an interim trade agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. The framework reaffirmed the countries’ commitment to the broader India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement negotiations. (PTI)

Fuel price hike due to global energy crisis: Minister

Union Minister G Kishan Reddy on Friday said the fuel price hike was unavoidable due to the global energy crisis and urged people to understand the circumstances behind the increase.

Responding to the fuel price hike by state-owned oil companies, he also alleged that opposition parties were trying to “provoke people.”

“The Government led by PM Narendra Modi ji took this step under unavoidable circumstances. No domestic issue is responsible for this. Countries and people across the world have been affected by the energy crisis,” Union Minister of Coal and Mines told reporters here.

He alleged that some parties were trying to incite people and spread misinformation about the issue.

Reddy appealed to the public to understand the inevitability of the price hike.

Although it was expected that the West Asia conflict would ease and fuel transportation would improve, crude oil shipments are still not reaching the country smoothly, he said. (PTI)

India, UK hope to resolve steel issue, implement CETA soon: Commerce Secy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and the UK are working on a “unique and creative solution” to address issues arising from Britain’s recent steel safeguard measure so that the proposed Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) can be operationalised at an early date, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Friday.

The two countries, on July 24, 2025, signed the agreement. “We are very near to operationalising that. There are a few sticking points, as you are aware, the UK has come ahead with a steel measure recently, which was not factored in while negotiating the India-UK deal. We are working together to find a unique, creative solution around the steel measure also so that we can operationalise the India-UK CETA at an early date,” he told reporters here.

From July 1, 2026, the UK will limit tariff-free steel imports, reducing overall quota volumes by 60 per cent compared to the steel safeguard measure. Any imports above these levels will then face a 50 per cent tariff.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | MAY 16, 2026

PSU banks write-offs to multi-year lows in FY26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ May

Loan write-offs by public sector banks declined to multi-year lows in the fiscal year 2025-26 on the back of lower slippages and better recoveries.

As per an analysis of bank earnings by PTI, most banks including Bank of Baroda, Union Bank of India, Punjab National Bank, Central Bank of India, Indian Overseas Bank, and Indian Bank had write-offs which were the lowest in up to eight years.

Bank of Baroda reported ₹6,330 crore write-offs in FY26, lowest since FY18, Bank of India reported ₹5,735 crore write-off lowest since FY16, and Indian Bank reported

₹6,695 crore write-off lowest since FY19, while Indian Overseas Bank’s write-off stood at ₹1,189 crore in FY26, which was also a multi-year low, the data compiled from banks’ investor presentations showed.

Central Bank of India reported a regular and technical write-off of ₹1,718 crore in FY26, lowest since FY22.

Banks typically write off loans when there is little chance of recovery through usual channels, and need to make 100 per cent provisions on such debt.

Loan write-offs help banks clean up their balance sheets and show lower non-performing assets (NPA) on their books. However, lenders insist that recovery efforts continue

even after a write-off, which leads to a write-back of the provisions made earlier and bolsters profits.

Sachin Sachdeva, vice president, sector head — financial sector ratings at ICRA said write-offs in the PSBs have been declining over the past few years and the same can

be attributed primarily to lower incremental slippages and healthy recoveries.

“Fresh non-performing advances (NPA) formation has declined steadily, and the existing pool of legacy stressed assets continues to shrink. Besides, PSBs have also strengthened their provi-

Crude oil futures rise amid fears of disruptions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices rose more than 3 per cent to ₹10,073 per barrel in futures trade on Friday, tracking sharp gains in global benchmarks amid concerns over supply disruptions triggered by the US-Iran war.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude oil for May delivery gained ₹349, or 3.59 per cent, to ₹10,073 per barrel in a business turnover of 9,898 lots.

Similarly, the July contract also advanced ₹344, or 3.68 per cent, to ₹9,694 per barrel in 9,315 lots.

Analysts said fears of tighter global supplies and continued disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz supported crude

oil prices. Global benchmarks also rallied sharply, with Brent oil for the July contract gaining \$3.54, or 3.35 per cent, to \$109.26 per barrel, while West Texas Intermediate (WTI) for June delivery rose nearly 4 per cent to \$105 per barrel in New York.

“Crude oil prices gained steam on Friday, with Brent

climbing to \$108 per barrel and WTI trading near \$105, headed for weekly gains of more than 6 per cent, fuelled by deepening concerns over supply disruptions linked to the ongoing US-Iran conflict,” Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities, said.

Stock markets close lower on weak rupee, inflation doubts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty surrendered early gains to close lower on Friday due to selling in metal, oil & gas and PSU bank shares and caution among investors amid surging crude oil prices.

The 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 160.73 points, or 0.21 per cent, to settle at 75,237.99, after swinging between gains and losses during the session. The benchmark had rallied nearly 470 points in early trade before losing momentum.

The 50-share NSE Nifty settled lower by 46.10 points, or 0.19 per cent, at 23,643.50, snapping its two-day gaining

streak. Tata Steel, State Bank of India, Eternal, Reliance Industries, UltraTech Cement, Mahindra & Mahindra, Bharat Electronics Ltd, Larsen & Toubro, Trent, Axis Bank and Asian Paints were the major laggards among Sensex stocks. On the other hand, Infosys, Tech Mahindra, PowerGrid, Adani Ports, Maruti Suzuki India, Bharti Airtel, Kotak Mahindra Bank, Hindustan Unilever, and Sun Pharmaceuticals were major winners. “Investors have turned cautious post the recent relief rally, with rising bond yields, a weaker rupee, and fresh fuel price hikes reviving inflation concerns,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

Index	Open	Previous Close	Low	High	Close	Change
NSE NIFTY	23,731.40	23,689.60	23,610.30	23,839.30	23,643.50	-46.10 (-0.19%)
BSE SENSEX	75,497.10	75,398.72	75,139.41	75,870.36	75,237.99	-160.73 (-0.21%)

Favourable valuations and a solid Q4 earnings print are cushioning the downside. Focus has shifted to potential

fiscal and monetary measures to defend the rupee and stabilise the Balance of Payment, he added.

Forex reserves jump by \$6.295b

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India’s forex reserves jumped by \$6.295 billion to \$696.988 billion during the week ended May 8, the Reserve Bank said on Friday.

The overall reserves had dropped by \$7.794 billion to \$690.693 billion in the previous reporting week.

The forex kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year, before the onset of the West Asia crisis, which led to several weeks of drop, as the rupee came under pressure and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended May 8, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by \$562 million to \$552.387 billion, the central bank’s data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include the effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves jumped by \$5.637 billion to \$120.853 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were up by \$84 million to \$18.873 billion, the apex bank said.

India’s reserve position with the IMF was also up by \$12 million to \$4.875 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank’s data.

Rupee hits record low of 96.14/USD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Indian rupee crashed below the 96/\$mark on Friday before closing at an all-time low of 95.86 (provisional) against the US dollar as elevated crude oil prices and inflation concerns added to the downside pressure on the rupee.

Rupee has registered over 6 per cent losses so far this year, and in the past six trading sessions, it has depreciated nearly 2 per cent as Iran war risk escalation pushed crude oil prices higher. The dollar index moved northwards after strong US retail sales and stable labour market data reduced expectations of aggressive Federal Reserve rate cuts.

Forex traders said global uncertainties, relatively high valuations, and the lack of AI-led investment opportunities have weighed on capital flows.

Moreover, weak net FDI inflows are likely to exert pressure on the balance of payments, while rising crude oil prices stoke inflation worries.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.86, then slumped to a record low of 96.14 in intraday trade, registering a fall of 50 paise from its previous close.

The USD/INR pair finally

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
May 8	94.49	-27p
May 9	95.28	-79p
May 10	95.68	-40p
May 11	95.66	+02p
May 12	95.64	+02p
May 13	95.86*	-22p
May 14	95.86*	-22p
May 15	95.86*	-22p

*Provisional
(Inverted scale) KBK Infographics

settled at 95.86 (provisional) against the US dollar, registering a fall of 22 paise from its previous close, helped by likely RBI intervention.

On Thursday, the rupee weakened to a fresh record low of 95.96 before closing with a marginal gain of 2 paise at 95.64 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.15, higher by 0.34 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading up 3.14 per cent at \$109.04 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic equity market front, Sensex fell 160.73 points to settle at 75,237.99, while Nifty declined 46.10 points to 23,643.50.

Exports clock 5-month high growth of 13.48 per cent in April

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Exports rose by 13.78 per cent to \$43.56 billion in April, the highest monthly outbound shipments in more than four years, driven by petroleum products amid a surge in crude oil prices, but trade deficit widened to a three-month high of \$28.38 billion due to an uptick in imports.

Imports grew by 10 per cent year-on-year to a six-month high of \$71.94 billion in April, inflating the trade deficit. The gap between imports and exports, or trade deficit, was \$27.1 billion in April 2025 and \$20.67 billion in March 2026. Commerce

Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said that despite global geopolitical tensions, the country’s exports are registering healthy growth. Exports grew at the fastest pace in five months in April.

“The positive growth in value may also have some contribution from the price because prices of many things are going up so that may have some positive impact,” he told reporters here.

The key drivers of exports include electronic goods (40.31 per cent), meat and dairy (48 per cent), petroleum products (34.66 per cent), engineering items (8.76 per cent), and pharmaceuticals (7.12 per cent). Electronic

exports rose to \$5.17 billion, while shipments of petroleum products were worth \$9.6 billion in April. Brent crude oil prices have risen by \$11.47, or nearly 12 per cent, to \$107.51 per barrel on May

15 from \$96.04 per barrel on March 16, 2026. At its peak, Brent crude had surged by \$30.37, or about 32 per cent, to \$126.41 per barrel on April 30 compared with the March 16 level.

Sugar export ban will trigger price crash, hurt factories, argue industry experts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Sugar industry experts have slammed the Centre’s sudden decision to ban sugar exports, warning that the move will trigger a domestic price crash, inflate debts of factories, and impact cultivators.

India has announced a ban on sugar export till September 30 this year to enhance domestic availability and contain prices. Banning exports of a commodity helps prevent price rise amid inflation concerns and uncertainty caused by the West Asia conflict.

Bhairavnath Thombre, president of the West Indian Sugar Mills Association, warned that domestic prices

have already begun to slide, and the sugar factories will find it difficult to clear their Fair and Remunerative Price (FRP) dues.

“When the Government’s sudden ban on exports till September 30 will tarnish the image of Indian sugar factories in the global market,” he said.

He said that India exports sugar to Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Afghanistan, Nepal and Arab countries,

and the ban will endanger businesses that have already negotiated deals with these countries.

“Factories in Maharashtra have a Fair and Remunerative Price (FRP) debt of nearly ₹1,550 crore, while the dues are around ₹12,000 crore nationally. The area under sugarcane cultivation may not decrease, but cultivators will not earn enough from their yield,” Thombre said. He noted that if the Government has banned sugar exports, it should increase the procurement of sugar-based ethanol.

The Government should increase ethanol use in petrol to 30 per cent from the current 20 per cent. This will increase ethanol procurement from the sugar factories, he said.

OMCs, paint stocks slide after fuel price hike

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Shares of oil marketing companies and paint manufacturers declined up to 3 per cent in early trade on Friday after petrol and diesel prices were increased by ₹3 per litre across the country.

The fuel price hike, the first in more than four years, amid mounting losses suffered by fuel retailers due to elevated global crude oil prices.

On the BSE, shares of Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd declined 2.71 per cent, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd dipped 2.39 per cent, Indian Oil Corporation fell 1.85 per cent.

The stock of paint manufacturers, which use crude-linked derivatives as key raw materials, also traded lower.

Indigo Paints declined 1.36 per cent, Asian Paints slipped 0.42 per cent, and Berger Paints India fell 0.14 per cent.

Analysts said the modest increase in retail fuel prices failed to fully offset concerns around elevated crude costs and put pressure on market margins.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, rose 1.23 per cent to \$107.02 per barrel.

“The sharp increase in petrol, diesel, and CNG prices reflects the direct impact of the escalating West Asia energy crisis and supply disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz,” Ajit Mishra” SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

With global crude oil prices surging from nearly \$69 in February to above \$120 per barrel and current-

ly at \$107 mark, oil marketing companies were under mounting pressure due to rising input costs and shrinking marketing margins, he added.

Energy prices globally shot up after the US-Israel attack on Iran on February 28, and the subsequent retaliation by Tehran effectively shut down the Strait of Hormuz - the sea lane through which a fifth of the world’s oil and gas transits.

Crude oil, the input raw material for making petrol and diesel, surged above \$120 per barrel during the peak of the West Asia conflict, as opposed to the \$70-72 range before the conflict.

Though prices have moderated in recent weeks, they continue to remain elevated around \$104-110 per barrel range, keeping pressure on state-owned fuel retailers.

FROM THE WORLD

UK

11 Far Right extremists blocked

Eleven foreign far-right extremists have been blocked from entering the UK ahead of massive protest rallies planned for the weekend, Prime Minister Keir Starmer said on Friday. One of those barred from the UK is US-based extremist Valentina Gomez, accused of using "inflammatory and dehumanising rhetoric" about Muslim communities. Starmer also took to social media with a video appeal for the British public to "fight for the soul of the country" as thousands are expected to converge upon central London on Saturday. There will also be a pro-Palestine counter-protest joined by Stand Up to Racism against the backdrop of what the Metropolitan Police has described as an security operation. "We're in a fight for the soul of this country, and the Unite the Kingdom march this weekend is a stark reminder of exactly what we are up against," said Starmer.

AUSTRALIA

Neo-Nazi group banned

Australia identified a neo-Nazi network as the second organization being banned under its new law criminalising hate groups and support for them. The group, formerly known as the National Socialist Network and sometimes called White Australia, said it would disband after the Government in January passed the law allowing certain organisations to be banned. The law was in response to the antisemitic attack on a Hanukkah celebration at Sydney's Bondi Beach in December in which 15 people were killed. The National Socialist Network "changed their name, but didn't change the fact that they were still an organization and were still engaging in the same sort of behavior that met the thresholds for this legislation," Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke told reporters in Canberra on Friday. The new law allowed for hate groups that didn't otherwise fit Australia's definition of a terrorist organisation to be banned.

China to buy 200 Boeing planes, deal may expand, says Trump

RIO YAMAT/BILL BARROW
■ On Board Air Force One

Aircraft manufacturer Boeing will make its first major sale to China in nearly a decade with an order for 200 planes, President Donald Trump told reporters on Air Force One on Friday, a deal he said had been made during his summit with China's President Xi Jinping this week and that could grow to as many as 750 planes. The White House has not released details of the deal, and the company itself has not commented. Boeing CEO Kelly Ortberg had joined Trump for the trip to Beijing, one of a large group of CEOs seeking to sell products and services to China. For Boeing,



President Donald Trump talking with China's President Xi Jinping at the Zhongnanhai leadership compound

the deal would mark a significant breakthrough in a market that was once central to its long-term growth. Trump also said the deal would benefit General Electric, which he said would supply 400 to 450 engines. General Electric did not immediately comment on

the agreement. Last month, Ortberg signalled confidence that any broader US-China agreement would include aircraft purchases, telling investors he expected Trump's meeting with Xi to be a "meaningful opportunity" for Boeing. Ortberg took over in 2024, a calamitous

year for Boeing as it came under intensifying scrutiny over production and quality failures and faced mounting financial pressure. In January 2024, a panel known as a door plug blew off a 737 Max shortly after takeoff from Portland, Oregon, renewing scrutiny of Boeing's manufacturing practices. Months later, the US Justice Department revived a criminal case against Boeing tied to the two fatal Max crashes, although prosecutors later reached an agreement with Boeing to dismiss the case, committing the company to an additional \$1.1 billion in fines, compensation for victims' families and internal safety and quality improvements. (PTI)



Personnel of the Indian Navy and Royal Malaysian Navy posing for a photograph onboard INS Sagardhwani during the ship's visit to Port Klang, Malaysia

Ceasefire with Iran is a favour to Pak: Trump

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump on Friday said he agreed to a ceasefire with Iran as a "favour" to Pakistan and ruled out any further bombing of the Persian Gulf nation, with which it has been in odds for several decades. The US and Israel's war on Iran started on February 28, and attacks have been paused since April 8, when the warring sides agreed to a ceasefire brokered by Pakistan. "We did the ceasefire as a request from another nation. I would have really benefited from it, but we did it as a favour to



Pakistan. They are terrific people, the Field Marshal and the Prime Minister," Trump told reporters on Air Force One while returning from China to the US. Trump reiterated his

resolve not to allow Iran to acquire nuclear weapons and to make them give up the enriched uranium Tehran has accumulated over the years. He said the Iranian negotiators were claiming that their nuclear facilities were damaged in the American air strikes and that they were not in a position to retrieve the nuclear fuel. "They came up with a terrible secret. They said that they can't remove it because they don't have the technology to remove it. They don't have the time and the practice," Trump said in response to questions on Iran. Trump said Chinese

President Xi Jinping was also in favour of opening up the Strait of Hormuz, which is a key trade route for 20 per cent of the global oil supplies. US Vice President JD Vance led a team of negotiators for the first-ever direct face-to-face talks with Iranian leaders in Islamabad on April 11-12, which got the warring nations into prolonged negotiations to end the decades-long hostilities. The US has been insisting that Iran give a clear commitment to end its uranium enrichment programme in exchange for the lifting of sanctions and the release of billions in frozen Iranian funds. (PTI)

UK Government faces weeks of uncertainty over the PM future

DANICA KIRKA
■ London

Britain's Government faces a prolonged period of uncertainty after a week of maneuvering within the governing Labour Party failed to oust Prime Minister Keir Starmer but started the clock on a leadership contest that could last well into the summer. Although Starmer vowed to fight on after a bruising week in which one Cabinet member resigned, dozens of lawmakers called for the prime minister to quit and his new policy proposals were largely ignored, some observers believe it's only a matter of time before he steps aside. The message of the past week "is that Labour seems to have made up its mind that Keir Starmer is going to have to go," said Tim Bale, a professor of politics at Queen Mary



University of London. Former Deputy Prime Minister Angela Rayner announced she had cleared up a tax issue that forced her to resign from the Cabinet last year, thus freeing her up as well.

Italian expert joins Maldives search after fatal dive accident

GIADA ZAMPANO
■ Rome

An Italian expert joined police divers and rescue vessels for searches in the Maldives on Friday, a day after five Italian divers were killed in a scuba accident, authorities said. Italy's Foreign Ministry said the five divers "apparently died while attempting to explore caves at a depth of 50 metres (164 feet)" on Thursday. It said the circumstances of their death remain under investigation. Maldivian authorities said they launched a major rescue operation after the incident on Thursday, deploying boats, aircraft and dive teams to search the area. One diver was found dead in a deep underwater cave, with the body recovered from nearly



60 metres (200 feet) below the surface, the Maldives National Defence Force said in statement. The remaining four divers were believed to be inside the same cave, and additional teams and specialized equipment were being sent for what officials described as a dangerous, high-risk operation. The Italian foreign ministry did not provide informa-

tion on the recovery of bodies. It said an Italian expert was assisting the coast guard and Maldivian vessels in the search operation on Friday. It said officials planned a dive to evaluate access to an underwater cave in the Vaavu Atoll, where the accident occurred, but rough weather conditions could delay the recovery. (AP)

FICCI delegation engages Chinese industry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shanghai

The Consulate General of India in Shanghai hosted a high-level interaction with a delegation from Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry (FICCI) led by FICCI President Anant Goenka on 15 May 2026, bringing together leading Indian industry representatives and prominent Chinese business leaders to explore opportunities for strengthening bilateral economic cooperation. In his keynote address, Consul General Pratik Mathur highlighted the achievements of India's ongoing economic transformation under the Government of India's vision of Viksit Bharat and Atmanirbhar Bharat. He emphasised that India's policy focus on resilient supply chains, ease of doing



business, digital public infrastructure, and manufacturing competitiveness — supported by initiatives such as Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes — has created significant opportunities for global partnerships. The Consul General noted that Eastern China, as a hub of advanced manufacturing and innovation, is well-posi-

tioned to partner with India in co-developing industrial ecosystems, scaling investments, and fostering technology collaboration. Highlighting the strengths of Indian industry, Shri Mathur reiterated FICCI's role as a key bridge between Indian and global businesses. He underscored the strong potential for collaboration in

sectors including advanced manufacturing, green technologies, digital economy, healthcare, and infrastructure. He also called for institutionalized industry linkages and sustained B2B engagement between India — the world's fastest-growing major economy — and enterprises across the region. The interaction served as a platform for substantive discussions on enhancing trade, investment flows, and technological cooperation between India and China. The Consul General of India in Shanghai reaffirmed its commitment to facilitating stronger engagement between Indian and Chinese stakeholders and supporting initiatives that contribute to mutually beneficial economic development.

FBI issues \$2,00,000 reward for ex-US spy in Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The FBI is offering a \$200,000 reward for information leading to capture and prosecution of a former US Air Force counterintelligence specialist who defected to Iran in 2013 and was later charged with revealing classified information to the Tehran Government. Monica Elfriede Witt, who is in her 40s, was indicted by a federal grand jury in February 2019 on charges of espionage, including transmitting national defence information to the Government of Iran. She remains at large. Witt "allegedly betrayed her oath to the Constitution more than a decade ago by defecting to Iran and providing the Iranian regime



National Defence Information and likely continues to support their nefarious activities," Daniel Wierzbicki, special agent in charge of the FBI Washington Field Office's Counterintelligence and Cyber Division, said in a news release Wednesday.

US official briefs nuclear industry delegation ahead of India visit

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US Energy Secretary Chris Wright briefed a delegation of senior executives from the American nuclear industry scheduled to visit India next week to explore areas of cooperation after New Delhi opened up the tightly-controlled sector for private players. A 20-member US executive nuclear industry delegation will interact with Government officials and private sector leaders keen to explore opportunities in the civil nuclear sector available since the enactment of the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) law in December last year. The SHANTI Act replaced the Atomic Energy Act of 1964 and the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage (CNLD) Act of 2010. The CNLD Act had tougher liability provisions on nuclear suppliers, which global companies found to be an impediment to exploring the Indian market. The US nuclear industry delegation is travelling to India as part of an initiative by the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum and the Nuclear Energy Institute. "USISPF and the Nuclear Energy Institute (@NEI) were honoured to welcome the US Secretary of Energy



US Energy Secretary Chris Wright

@SecretaryWright for a briefing with members of the US Executive Nuclear Industry Delegation ahead of their visit to India," the USISPF said in a social media post. The US industry delegation is expected to explore joint project opportunities with the Indian private sector in civil nuclear energy. "India's ambition to scale nuclear capacity to 100 GW by 2047, combined with the opening of the sector to private players, presents a major commercial opportunity for US firms," Shaswat Kumar, Fellow, Centre for Strategic and International Studies said. He said recent 10 CFR Part 810 authorisations to Holtec, Clean Core Thorium and Flowserve signal renewed momentum in bilateral nuclear cooperation. "Going forward, realising this potential will hinge on parallel action - faster export approvals from the US and, in India, progress on reprocess-

ing infrastructure and addressing end use verification concerns," Kumar said. After the India-US civil nuclear agreement was signed in 2008, two sites Chhayamithi Virdi in Gujarat and Kovvada in Andhra Pradesh were allotted to US companies to establish 1000 MW nuclear power plants. India and the US are also exploring cooperation in small modular reactors (SMRs), which are billed as the future of nuclear power due to ease of deployment, particularly by repurposing sites of coal-based power plants. "Legislations like the SHANTI Act and EO14299 have led to a revival of dialogue on nuclear energy in both India and the US. We can expect more opportunities for private companies from the two countries to collaborate in this sector," said Abhik Sengupta, a programme officer with a Washington-based industry body. (PTI)

verka		
THE PUNJAB STATE CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD. SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022, EPABX NO. 0172-5041812, 66		
Notice Inviting Tender		
www.verka.coop		
e Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-		
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Head Office, Chandigarh Hiring of Swift Dzire car (AC) or equivalent vehicle along with driver to be provided on hire basis.	01 No.
2.	For Verka Branch Sales Office, Delhi Hiring of commercial vehicles for supply of Verka milk products and other material from products store of Milkfed Branch sales office delhi at 5751, Verka House, Dush Bandhu, Gupta Road, Dev Nagar Karol Bagh delhi-110005 upto 500kg, 750 kg, 1250 kg, 1700 kg, 3500 kg, 4500 kg, 6000 kg & 10,000 kg for supply of Verka Milk Products from Milkfed Branch Sales Office to different station of Delhi/NCR area.	Annual initially & may be extended for another equal period
3.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy a) Disposal of unserviceable scrap material/Vehicles one time basis. b) Design supply installation & Commissioning of 2 No's of gas cum oil fired package boiler capacity (1x60) TPH & (1x8) TPH along with allied civil works and dismantling of existing two numbers of 5TPH oil fired boilers. c) Supply installation & Commissioning of 160 No's of batteries for 300*2 KVA UPS of powder plant. d) Hiring of passenger vehicles for following sections:- procurement, marketing, accounts/ admin, sale depot, quality assurance w.e.f. 01.07.2026 to 30.06.2027. Car (Swift Dzire, Toyota Etios or Equivalent or Sub Compact SUV).	Annual/As per site 01 Job 01 Job No's of vehicles may be increased or decreased 09 No's
4.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy a) Transportation of LSHS/HPS (Heavy Petroleum Stock) from Panipat /Mathura Refinery to Verka Ludhiana Dairy. b) Hiring of Vehicles :- i. Tempo for Cattle feed/ milk products/technical services. ii. Tempo for transportation of Milk through cans. iii. Jeep Camper Type. c) Outsourcing of operation and maintenance activities of boiler and air-heater section.	Annual 02 No's 04 No's 01 No's One Job
5.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Hiring of car (Boloro, swift dzire, Toyota Etios or Equivalent) required for procurement activities.	01 No.
6.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy i. Wall/Shutter/Vehicles painting in the areas of District- Sangrur, Barnala & Malerkolla. ii. Supply of flex banners, flex boards, glow sign boards, vinyl sticker, vinyl with eco solvent printing, sun board and one way vision etc. in the areas of District-Sangrur, Barnala & Malerkolla.	Annual Annual
7.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy Hiring of insulated Single portion road milk tankers for the transportation of Milk from BMC/MCC.	Two year/ 03 No's
8.	For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Bhatian (Khanna) a) Transportation of finished Cattle feed, Mineral feed mixture and UML to various station of Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan. Capacity an average per day, (Qty, increase/ decrease as per demand. b) Auction of Unserviceable Material.	Annual/ 02-05 trucks of 5MTs/6MTs 08-10 trucks of 10MTs to 12MTs 04-06 trucks of 13MTs to 16MTs 06-08 trucks of 18 MTs and above 18 MTs 01 No.
NOTE: 1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in. 2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
1018/12/2026-27/11512		General Manager (Purchase)

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD
JALUKBARI TERRITORIAL ROAD DIVISION, FANCY
BAZAR, GUWAHATI-01

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDERE
Executive Engineer PWD, Jalukbari Territorial Road Division, Fancy Bazar, Ghy-01, on behalf of Governor of Assam invites bid for 80 (Eighty) Nos of works in F2 Form under SOPD-G for 2025-26 in Kamrup District of Assam amounting to 548.422 L (approx.) in Jalukbari LAC under Kamrup District. Details may be seen in the office of the undersigned from 18.05.2026 during office hours.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer PWD
Jalukbari Territorial Road Division,
Fancy Bazar, Ghy-01
DIPR/CF/PIO/133/16-MAY-26

New Ebola outbreak in Congo kills 65

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kinshasa

Africa CDC, the continent's top public health body, on Friday confirmed a new Ebola outbreak in Congo's remote Ituri province, with 246 suspected cases and 65 deaths recorded so far.

The deaths and suspected cases have been recorded mainly in the Mongwalu and Rwampara health zones, the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said in a statement.

The Ebola virus is highly contagious and can be contracted through bodily fluids such as vomit, blood, or semen. The disease it causes is rare, but severe and often fatal.

"Four deaths have been reported among laboratory-confirmed cases. Suspected cases have also been reported in Bunia, pending confirmation," the agency said, referring to the

capital of Ituri province, near the border with Uganda.

It said preliminary laboratory results have detected the Ebola virus in 13 of 20 samples tested.

The latest outbreak comes around five months after Congo's last Ebola outbreak was declared over after 43 deaths. Ituri is in a remote eastern part of Congo characterised by poor road networks, and is more than 1,000 kilometres from the nation's capital of Kinshasa.

Africa CDC said it is concerned about the risk of further spread due to intense population movement, mining-related mobility in Mongwalu, insecurity in affected areas, gaps in contact listing and control challenges.

The proximity of affected areas to Uganda and South Sudan also raises concerns, it said. The agency said it is convening an urgent high-level coordination meeting



Friday with health authorities from Congo, Uganda and South Sudan, together with key partners including UN agencies and other countries. "The meeting will focus on immediate response priorities, cross-

border coordination, surveillance, laboratory support, infection prevention and control, risk communication, safe and dignified burials, and resource mobilisation," it said. This is the 17th outbreak in Congo

from 2014 to 2016 also killed more than 11,000 people. The new outbreak will create more worry for the Central African country, which has been battling various armed groups in the east, including the M23 rebel group, which launched a rapid assault in January last year and has since occupied key cities.

Ituri in particular is also battling violence from the Allied Democratic Force, an Islamic State-linked militant group which has killed dozens there and in other parts of the east.

Congo, Africa's second-largest country by land area, often faces logistical challenges in responding to disease outbreaks. During last year's outbreak, which lasted three months, the World Health Organisation initially faced significant challenges in delivering vaccines due to limited access and scarce funds.

INDIA'S ENVOY IN BEIJING DISCUSSES BILATERAL TIES WITH CHINESE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

India's new envoy to China Vikram Doraiswami has held an introductory meeting with Director General of China's Department of Boundary and Ocean Affairs Hou Yanqi, dis-

cussing developments concerning the border and bilateral relations.

"The two sides had a productive exchange of views on developments related to the India-China border areas and reviewed the positive momentum in bilateral rela-

tions," the Embassy of India in Beijing said in a post on X on Thursday. "Both sides agreed to leverage established mechanisms to implement the vision of the two leaders towards a stable and mutually beneficial relationship," it added.

Norway backs cancelled missile deal with Malaysia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kuala Lumpur(Malaysia)

Norway's foreign ministry affirmed Friday it has revoked export licenses tied to a naval missile system for Malaysia, saying sales of its most sensitive defence technologies are now restricted to allies and closest partners.

The move blocked delivery of the Naval Strike Missile system and launcher components intended for Malaysia's littoral combat ship programme, prompting sharp protests from Kuala Lumpur. Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim warned it could damage confidence in European defence suppliers. Norway's foreign ministry said in reply to Associated Press queries that the Government has strengthened oversight on defence technology in response to major shifts in the security landscape in Europe and globally in recent years. "Exports of some of the most sensitive Norwegian-developed defence technologies will be limited to our allies and closest partners," it said. "It is regrettable that this affects Malaysia."

Malaysia inked a deal for the NSM anti-ship missile system in 2018 with Norway's Kongsberg Defence and Aerospace AS. The missiles were intended to arm Malaysia's new class of littoral combat ships under a broader naval modernisation program. Anwar said Thursday he raised Malaysia's strong protest during a phone call with Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre.

He said Oslo's move would hurt Malaysia's operational readiness and cast



doubt on the reliability of European defence partners if signed agreements could be reversed unilaterally.

Contracts are "not content to be scattered in so capricious a manner," Anwar said. "If European defence suppliers reserve the right to renege with impunity, their value as strategic partners flies out the window."

The Norway foreign ministry said Støre had explained Norway's deci-

sion to Anwar during their call. Despite the curbs, it said Norway "greatly values its relationship with Malaysia" and looked forward to continued cooperation and constructive dialogue with Malaysian authorities.

Malaysia has already paid 95 per cent of the contract value and is now examining legal options and possible compensation claims over the cancelled delivery.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM

Ref: i) Tender Notice No. 05/2026-2027 dated 21.04.2026.
ii) Tender No.08260001A due on 25.05.2026.

01. In reference to above tender, the due date has been extended from **15.05.2026 to 25.05.2026**. All other terms & conditions remain unchanged. The Corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in.

1632/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:

Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
08260508A	Commissioning of Universal Fail Safe Block Interface	42 Nos/Pair	08.06.26
122600031	Earthing Cable Complete for Wheel Set Earthing	11915 Nos	08.06.26
09262056	Bolster Bottom Gusset	2312 Nos	08.06.26

NOTE -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No Manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 12/ 2026-2027 Dated: 15.05.2026

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 1634/2026

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre/ RACPC-2, Rama Complex
Sohna Road, Badshahpur, Gurgaon-122016
E-mail: sbi.63774@sbi.co.in

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002. Hereinafter Called "ACT"
A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.
DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. MOHAN DEVS/ O.SH. ANAND PRAKASH H.No. 13/337 B, Block-13, Geeta Colony, Gandhi Nagar, East Delhi-110031. MAHALAXMI ENTERPRISES 2815/18, Street No.17, Kailash Nagar, East Delhi-110031 TL -A/c. No.: 44366590948	Make & Model: THAR ROXX AX7L D AT RWD Regn. No.: HR26FY8118 Engine No.: KYS4058992 Chassis No.: MA1UN2KY7S2D18246 Type: Diesel Registration Date: 17.10.2025	12/03/2026 Date of N.P.A. 11.03.2026	Rs.21,26,027.00 (Rupees Twenty One Lakh Twenty Six Thousand Twenty Seven Only) as on 11/03/2026 plus further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.
The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
DATE: 15.05.2026 PLACE: GURUGRAM

Sd/- Authorized Officer (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre-2, Gurugram

Death toll in attack on Kyiv apartment now stands at 24

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday that a Russian missile attack on a Kyiv apartment building the previous day killed 24 people, including what local officials said were three teenagers.

Emergency workers finished digging through the building's rubble after more than a day, Zelenskyy said on X. The cruise missile hit the nine-story corner block during what the Ukrainian air force said was Russia's biggest barrage of the country since its all-out invasion. The assault mostly targeted the Ukrainian capital, where 48 people were wounded, including two children, Zelenskyy said.

Russia hammered Ukraine with large-scale aerial attacks in the days following a May 9-11 ceasefire that US President Donald Trump



said he asked Zelenskyy and Russian President Vladimir Putin to observe. Fighting went on over those 72 hours, although reportedly on a lesser scale.

This week's attacks ran counter to recent suggestions from Trump and Putin that the war, now in its fifth year, is close to ending.

Zelenskyy said Thursday that Moscow had launched more than 1,560 drones

against Ukrainian population centres since Wednesday. In all, some 180 sites across the country were damaged, including more than 50 residential buildings, he said.

Previously, the biggest Russian drone attack was from the evening of March 23 to the evening of March 24 when Moscow's forces fired nearly 1,000 drones and missiles at Ukraine.

Indonesia's first panda cub is healthy ahead his public debut



EDNA TARIGAN
■ Cisarua(Indonesia)

The first giant panda born in Indonesia squirmed as veterinarians checked his hearing and eyesight and confirmed the furry cub was growing and healthy Friday before his public debut later this month. Satrio Wiratama, nicknamed "Rio," can walk on his own, climbs on his mother and has started eating bamboo shoots. He has grown to 10 kilograms (22 pounds) at 169 days old.

Veterinarians are monitoring his development to determine how well he might adapt to the crowds when he debuts at Indonesian Safari Park outside the capital, Jakarta. "What's important to note is that all of Rio's senses are active; he has the ability to

understand the environment, assess the situation, adapt to more people, and hear sounds, even in certain levels of noise. We will train him gradually," said Bongot Huaso Mulia, a veterinarian who monitors Rio's progress.

His growth in some ways is faster than average, especially his teeth, according to Mulia. Rio was born November 27 to his mother, Hu Chun, and a male panda, Cai Tao, who are both 15 years old. The pair arrived in Indonesia in 2017 on a 10-year conservation partnership with China. They live in an enclosure built for them at the park about 70 kilometres (43 miles) from the capital in Cisarua, West Java province. The two adult pandas have a large fan base in Indonesia. (AP)

Sri Lankan court orders arrests in bank fraud case



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

A Sri Lankan court has ordered more arrests in the National Development Bank (NDB) case involving \$42 million fraud, days after four staff members were arrested and sent to remand.

The chief magistrate's

court on Thursday ordered the arrest of more employees of the NDB in what is being termed as one of Sri Lanka's biggest bank frauds.

Four employees of the NDB were arrested early in May after the fraud was detected in April at the publicly quoted bank.

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम सागर

क्र./ लोककर्म/न.नि./2026/07 सागर दिनांक 14/05/26

:: ऑनलाईन निविदा सूचना ::
(द्वितीय आमंत्रण)

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत टेकेदारों से ऑन लाईन निविदायें आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेण्डर क्रमांक जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की लागत राशि रु. एवं समयावधि	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं ई.एस.डी.	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
1.	2026_UAD_506940_1 14.05.2026	मुख्यमंत्री शहरी अयोधरचना विकास योजना (चतुर्थ चरण) अंतर्गत 18 विभिन्न स्थानों पर सड़को का निर्माण कार्य	7,97,14,78+00 6 माह	20,000+00 3,99000+00	28.05.2026 शाम 5:30 तक

नोट: निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑन लाईन <https://mptenders.gov.in> की वेबसाईट पर हो किया जावेगा, पृथक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जावेगा।

आयुक्त
नगर पालिक निगम
सागर


सत्यमेव जयते

Government of India
Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (Divyangjan)
5th Floor, Pt. Deendayal Antoyadaya Bhawan, CGO Complex, Lodhi Raod, New Delhi

INVITING ONLINE APPLICATIONS FOR NATIONAL AWARDS FOR EMPOWERMENT OF PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES FOR THE YEAR- 2026

The Rashtriya Puraskar Portal for receiving applications/ nominations for National Awards for Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities, for the year 2026 is open w.e.f. 15th May, 2026 to 31st July, 2026. The details are as under:

- Applications/ Nominations may be filed online on Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (www.awards.gov.in).
- All Applications/Nominations for the National Awards for the year 2026 received upto 31st July, 2026 will be considered.
- Applications for the year 2026 are required to be submitted online only through the Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (www.awards.gov.in). The nomination should contain all relevant details as specified in the format available on the portal, clearly highlighting the notable and inspiring achievements in narrative form. Supporting documents relating to the achievements should also be uploaded on the portal. For the sub-categories namely, Sarvshreshth Divyangjan (Most Outstanding Person with Disabilities), Shreshth Divyangjan (Outstanding Person with Disabilities), and Shreshth: Srijansheel Divyang Bal/Balika (Outstanding Creative Divyang Child), uploading of the UDID Card/Disability Certificate is mandatory.
- Application in physical mode or any other mode will not be accepted.**
- For eligibility criteria and other details, Guidelines for National Awards for Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities available on the website of the Department (www.depwd.gov.in) as well as on the Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (www.awards.gov.in) may be referred to.

Sd/-
Ajay Kumar
Under Secretary to the Govt. of India
Tele:011-24369057

CBC 38117/11/0001/2627

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public that Mrs. Nareen W/o Mr. Imran Khan, intends to purchase Built up First Floor without roof of property no. 207/A, area measuring 80 Sq. Yds. Gali No. 27, carved out of Kharsa no. 438, Situated at Tughlakabad Extn., New Delhi 110019. The said property is being purchased from Mr. Ishrat Khan S/o Late Mr. Kishwar Khan. The Seller acquired the aforesaid property by virtue of a Notarized General Power of Attorney, along with a Special Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell, and Will, were rectified Deed dated 04.08.2025 on account of correction/change in the Kharsa Number. It is further stated that the property is proposed to be mortgaged with Shubham Housing Development Finance Company Ltd. for the purpose of obtaining financial assistance from the said Bank. The Original Notarized General Power of Attorney along with Special Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell and Will dated 22.05.2023 in favour of Mr. Ishrat Khan S/O Late Mr. Kishwar Khan, are unavailable as they have been destroyed. Any person having any claim or objection must notify the undersigned in writing within 7 days, failing which it will be presumed that no objections.

NCR LAW ASSOCIATES, Advocate & Consultants, A-98, Sector-09, New Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201009 Mob. Nos. 9999721152/ 9999826427

THE PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that our clients, Shri Yugul Kishore Kashyap, S/o Late Shri Nand Kishore, and Smt. Parveen Kashyap, W/o Shri Yugul Kishore Kashyap, both R/o House No. 128D, Pocket J&K, Dilshad Garden, Delhi - 110095, have completely severed all relations with their son, Shri Harsh Kishore Kashyap, and daughter-in-law, Ms. Nidhi Kashyap, W/o Shri Harsh Kishore Kashyap. My clients have also disowned and debarred Shri Harsh Kishore Kashyap and Ms. Nidhi Kashyap from any rights, claims, or inheritance in their entire movable and immovable properties due to their unsocial and uncooperative behavior. Any person dealing with them or acting on any cause created by them shall do so entirely at their own cost, risk, and responsibility. Our clients shall not be held liable in any manner for their deeds, acts, or conduct.

Rajendra Kumar Kasana (Advocate)
Chamber No. 8-86, B.G.S. Block, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054.

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Rajeev Chauhan S/o Madan Lal R/o of 6684, Quila Kadam Sharif, Swami Ram Tirth Nagar, Nabi Karim, Pahar Ganj, Delhi-110055, declare that Rajeev Kumar Chauhan and Rajeev Chauhan both are one and the same person.

PD(1122)C
I, Urmila Devi, Mother of No.14659459X Hav Sandip Kumar, R/o- Vill & Post- Birhar, Teh- Ghatampur, Dist- Kanpur (Nagar), U.P.- 209209, have changed my name from Urmila Devi to Urmila, vide affidavit dated 15/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1123)C
I, Krishna Karmakar Sarkar, W/o No.4297838M Sep Pallab Sarkar, R/o- Vill-PO- Hridaypur, ES- Barasat, Dist- North 24 Parganas, W.B- 700127 have changed my name from Krishna Karmakar Sarkar to Krishna Karmakar, vide affidavit dated 15/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1124)C
I, Shri Ramsajivan Mishra, Father of No.14659459X Hav Sandip Kumar, R/o- Vill & Post- Birhar, Teh- Ghatampur, Dist- Kanpur (Nagar), U.P.- 209209, have changed my name from Shri Ramsajivan Mishra to Ramsajivan, vide affidavit dated 15/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1125)C

I, Diksha Chauhan W/o- No.15691797Y Hav Gaurav Pratap, R/o- Vill/PO- Salempur, Teh & Dist- Mainpuri, U.P.- 205265, in my husband's service documents, my name is erroneously published as Deeksha Singh whereas my correct name is Diksha Chauhan which may be amended accordingly for all future purposes.

PD(1126)C
I, Susheela Bai, Mother of No.13628400A Nk Mannmohan Singh SM R/o- Vill- Bhilkhedhi Sadak, PO- Lasudiya Khas, Teh- Ashta, Dist- Sehore, M.P.- 466114, have changed my name from Susheela Bai to Sushila Bai, vide affidavit dated 15/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1127)C
I, hitherto known as Kunwarpal Singh S/o Pyare Singh R/o H.No W-302, Chander Shekhar Azad Gali No. 10, Babarpur, VTC: Shahdara, East Delhi, Delhi- 110032 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Kanwarpal Singh.

PD(1128)C
I, Pradeep S/o Hoshiar Singh Chandel R/o Flat No. 505, Raison Armor Homes, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Pradeep Chandel for all future purposes.

PD(1129)C

BRIEFLY

World Cup releases official song



The World Cup – officially – has an official song. Shakira and Nigerian singer-songwriter Burna Boy have combined to release “Dai Dai,” FIFA said in a statement Friday.

“Dai Dai brings together the global sounds and energy of Shakira and Burna Boy in a vibrant celebration of football, culture and unity,” FIFA said.

In early May, Colombian singer Shakira foreshadowed Friday’s news by sharing a minute-long teaser clip of a new song, writing on social media: “From Maracana Stadium, here is “Dai Dai,” the FIFA World Cup Official Song 2026.”

FIFA said royalties from the song, which is available on major streaming platforms, will support the FIFA Global Citizen Education Fund.

On Thursday, FIFA announced that the final on July 19 in New Jersey will feature a star-studded halftime show headlined by Madonna, Shakira and boy band BTS. (AP)

Ancelotti extends Brazil deal to 2030 World Cup

Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti has extended his contract with the team until the 2030 World Cup. The 66-year-old Italian coach, who took over in May 2025, had already hinted the extension was likely and confirmed the deal in a video published by the Brazilian soccer confederation, CBF, on Thursday.

The announcement comes shortly before Ancelotti reveals his Brazil squad for the upcoming World Cup on Monday.

“I arrived in Brazil a year ago. From the first minute, I understood what football means to this country. For a year, we have been working to take the Brazilian national team back to the top of the world. But the CBF and I want more,” Ancelotti said. “More victories, more time, more work. We are very happy to announce that we will continue together for another four years. We will go together until the 2030 World Cup.”

The former Real Madrid and AC Milan coach has had a troubled spell in Brazil so far, with many injured players and doubts as to whether his team can be a serious contender for the title at the tournament in North America. Under Ancelotti, Brazil has five wins, three losses and two draws in 10 games. Ancelotti replaced Dorival Junior last year after some lackluster performances and had to scramble quickly to complete South American qualifying for the World Cup. (AP)

Mbappe says coach made him the team’s 4th-choice striker

Kylian Mbappe said after not starting in Real Madrid’s Spanish league soccer match against Oviedo on Thursday that coach Alvaro Arbeloa told him that he is the team’s fourth-choice striker.

Arbeloa appeared to be caught by surprise by Mbappe’s words and said he never told him that. He said he doesn’t know why Mbappe felt like that.

Mbappe, who had been nursing a left hamstring injury, said he was ready to play from the start against Oviedo but Arbeloa decided not to use him.

“I’m 100 per cent fine,” Mbappe said. “I didn’t play because the coach told me I’m the fourth striker in the squad behind (Franco) Mastantuono, Vini (Vinicius Junior) and Gonzalo (Garcia). I accept it. I was ready to start, it was his decision. You can’t be angry with the coach, you always have to respect the opinion of the coach. I’ll keep working hard and wait to be the starter.”

Arbeloa later said he never told Mbappe he was the fourth striker in the squad. (AP)

Israeli minister criticizes Yamal for waving Palestinian flag



Israel’s defense minister has criticized Barcelona’s teenage star Lamine Yamal for his waving of a Palestinian flag during celebrations of the Spanish league title win, saying the act “incites hate.”

“Lamine Yamal chose to incite hate against Israel while our soldiers combat the terrorist organization Hamas, an organisation that massacred, raped and burned Jewish children, women and the elderly on Oct. 7, (2023)” minister Israel Katz wrote on X on Thursday.

The 18-year-old Yamal waved a large Palestinian flag from an open-top bus during a victory parade by Barcelona’s team through the city on Monday. The parade drew some 750,000 people to celebrate the league title clinched the previous day, local authorities said.

Yamal, who is Muslim, posted pictures of him holding the flag on his Instagram account.

Mexico City braces for FIFA World Cup

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ ■ Mexico City

Mexico City, the most populous city in North America, is a vibrant, bustling metropolis that blends rich history with modern culture. Whether you are marveling at ancient ruins or enjoying contemporary art, there is a palpable energy in the air and it will be present during the World Cup this summer.

With a metropolitan area of some 23.1 million people, traffic congestion is quite intense during rush hours, especially in the area near Azteca stadium. The city has pollution issues that could also be a problem for fans with respiratory conditions. Remember, too, that the city is at an altitude over 7,300 feet (2,240 meters), which may require some acclimatization for visitors.



Landmarks/places to see

Zocalo: One of the largest city squares in the world at some 14 acres (5.5 hectares), it is surrounded by the Metropolitan Cathedral and the National Palace. It’s a hub of activity and a great place to soak in the city’s history. It has been a gathering place for centuries.

Chapultepec Park: This massive park houses museums, a zoo and beautiful lakes. It’s perfect for leisurely walks and outdoor fun. The park is more than twice the size than New York’s Central Park, covering nearly 2,000 acres (800 hectares).

Teotihuacan: Located outside

the city, this ancient Mesoamerican city features the famous Pyramid of the Sun and Pyramid of the Moon. A must-visit for history enthusiasts.

Food scene in Mexico City: Mexico City’s culinary scene is a world-class, diverse and vibrant experience, blending traditional street food with innovative high-end dining. Street tacos and stalls offer authentic flavors throughout the city, while neighborhoods like Roma and Condesa feature renowned establishments, including Michelin-starred spots.

Fan zones: Mexico City plans to have 18 public venues that will broadcast World Cup matches free of charge, with no alcohol sales and a variety of cultural and sporting activities.

Seven of these venues will operate throughout the 39 days of the tournament, broadcasting all

104 matches, while the remaining 11 will screen games featuring the Mexican national team and other highlights.

Transportation options: The fastest way to get to the World Cup stadium is public transportation. The Metro Line 2 takes you to the Taxquena station where you need to change to the light rail to the Estadio Azteca station. You can also use the Metro Line 3 to the Universidad station and an electric bus will get you to the stadium. There are park-and-ride options at designated venues.

Stadium tips: Although the stadium was renovated for the World Cup, the improvements didn’t fix many problems, including the internet, which remains intermittent and can be problematic since cash payments are no longer accepted. (AP)

Saudi Arabia continues its soccer push with World Cup deal

JAMES ROBSON ■ Manchester

Saudi Arabia’s sovereign wealth fund may have pulled back from golf, but on Thursday it deepened its investment in soccer by becoming an “official tournament supporter” of the World Cup.

The kingdom’s public investment fund (PIF) announced this month that it was pulling the plug on future funding for LIV Golf, raising questions about its long-term plans for other sports after its enormous spending in recent years.

But in announcing the partnership, it said sport was a “priority sector.”

The value of the deal, which covers North America and Asia, was not disclosed, but it further strengthens ties between Saudi Arabia and world soccer’s governing body.

The oil-rich kingdom has



won the rights to host the 2034 edition of the World Cup and PIF was a commercial partner for last year’s Club World Cup.

The PIF-owned SURJ Sports Investment also owns a stake online streamer DAZN, which broadcast

looks to move away from its heavy reliance on oil and look to other revenue-generating sectors.

That has included enticing some of the sport’s biggest stars like Cristiano Ronaldo, Neymar and Karim Benzema to its domestic league and buying Premier League club Newcastle. Winning the right to host the World Cup is its stand-out achievement so far.

Investment in other sports includes hosting a number of world championship boxing matches, Formula One racing and tennis.

The launch of the contentious LIV Golf tour in 2022 was a major disruptor for the sport, luring top players like Bryson DeChambeau, Phil Mickelson, Brooks Koepka and Dustin Johnson away from the PGA. LIV Golf’s spending is expected to exceed \$6 billion by the end of the year. (AP)

Jannik Sinner breaks Masters record

ANDREW DAMPF ■ Rome

Jannik Sinner is two victories away from becoming the first home male player to win the Italian Open in half a century. And it doesn’t seem like anybody can stop him — either in Rome or at the French Open that starts in 10 days.

The top-ranked Sinner landed shots on the lines repeatedly in a 6-2, 6-4 triumph over No. 14 Andrey Rublev to reach the semifinals Thursday and move past Novak Djokovic with a record 32nd consecutive victory in Masters 1000 events — the biggest tournaments outside the Grand Slams.

“I don’t play for records. I play just for my own story. And obviously at the same time it means a lot to me,” Sinner said.

The last Italian man to raise the singles trophy on the red clay of the Foro Italico was Adriano Panatta in 1976. Panatta will present the title to this year’s cham-



pion on Sunday, with Italian President Sergio Mattarella also slated to attend the final.

“It’s a special tournament for me,” Sinner said.

Sinner’s semifinal opponent will be 2023 Rome champion Daniil Medvedev, who came back to beat Spanish qualifier Martin Landaluce 1-6, 6-4, 7-5.

The other semifinal will feature Casper Ruud of Norway against Luciano

Darder, an Argentine-born Italian.

Huge partisan support: With nearly everyone inside the 10,500-seat Campo Centrale cheering for Sinner, many supporters wore hats and T-shirts in orange — his theme color.

One group of fans held up a sign that said, “Sinner, Facce Sogna” — “Sinner, Make us dream.”

Sinner lost last year’s final in Rome to Carlos Alcaraz, who is now sidelined due to a right wrist injury, while Jasmine Paolini in 2025 became the first Italian woman to raise the trophy in 40 years.

Sinner broke serve in the opening game for a third straight match and never lost control against Rublev, who was once ranked as high as No. 5.

Rublev noticed there were “many points where he played really well or close to the line or in a line. But he’s No. 1 and it’s normal. You need to force him to miss and it takes a lot of focus to be able to play at that level.”

Sinner had only one brief lapse when Rublev broke him late in the second set.

“It was a bit breezy, a bit windy, so it was very tough conditions,” Sinner said. “I felt we both didn’t play at our best today.” (AP)

Deschamps unveils France’s star-studded World Cup squad



SAMUEL PETREQUIN ■ Paris

France coach Didier Deschamps assembled a squad with formidable attacking talent for the World Cup and rewarded goalkeeper Robin Riser with a call-up for the showpiece tournament on Thursday following his breakthrough season.

Risser, who plays for Lens, has been one of the revelations of the French league season and won the award for the best goalkeeper earlier this

week. He played a big role in making Lens the second-best defense in Ligue 1 and was selected by Deschamps in a No. 3 role behind Mike Maignan and Brice Samba.

“I’m full of pride, it’s something incredible,” Risser told broadcaster TF1. “I can’t find the words. It’s just extraordinary. It was one of my dreams.”

France is looking for a third World Cup title and is among the favorites for the event taking place from June 11-July 19 in Canada, Mexico, and the United States.

France has been drawn in Group I and will take on Senegal, Iraq and Norway during the group stage.

Deschamps is gifted with an impressive attacking reservoir including Kylian Mbappe, Ballon d’Or winner Ousmane Dembele, rising star Desire Doue, Michael Olise, Rayan Cherki and Maghnes Aklouches.

He also called up Crystal Palace forward Jean-Philippe Mateta, who was preferred to Randal Kolo Muani in his 26-man list. The Tottenham striker had been a late addition to France’s previous World Cup squad four years ago. Kolo Muani scored a goal against Morocco in the semifinals and came close of becoming a national hero in the final before France lost to Argentina in a penalty shootout. (AP)

Mbappe among players jeered by Real Madrid fans

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Real Madrid fans made their discontentment known Thursday by jeering players at the Santiago Bernabeu stadium before a 2-0 win over already relegated Oviedo. Kylian Mbappe came on as a substitute after an injury layoff and was booed by part of the crowd, as was Vinicius Junior earlier. “I’ve being booed before in my career,” Mbappe said. “It’s part of it. Sometimes they are not happy”

A couple of banners against president Florentino Perez were held up briefly before being removed by security officials. Perez saluted some of the fans, but at one point he appeared to get into an verbal altercation with some of the team’s supporters near the VIP tribunes, according to Spanish media reports.

The match capped a chaotic week for Madrid, which started with an altercation between players in training that led the club to fine Federico Valverde and Aurelien Tchouameni 500,000 euros (\$589,000) each. Then came the loss to Barcelona in the clasico on Sunday that allowed its rival to clinch the league title, and on Tuesday Perez called for new elections



after saying he was the victim of an “organised campaign” to unseat him.

An edgy Perez confronted journalists and made widespread accusations in a hastily scheduled news conference.

Madrid has endured two straight seasons without winning a major title. It was eliminated by Bayern Munich in the quarterfinals of the Champions League, was ousted by second-division club Albacete in the Copa del Rey and lost the Spanish Super Cup final to Barcelona.

Garcia put Madrid ahead in the 43rd minute and Jude Bellingham sealed the win in the 79th after

Sahith Theegala opens with strong first round at PGA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Newtown Square (US)

India-American Sahith Theegala produced a composed two-under-par 68 to place himself firmly in contention at the close of a demanding first round at the 2026 PGA Championship at Aronimink Golf Club here.

On a day when scoring proved difficult and several elite names faltered, Theegala’s disciplined opening round stood out well.

The leaderboard is crowded and dangerous. Defending champion and world number one Scottie Scheffler finished among a seven-way tie for the lead at three-under 67, joined by Martin Kaymer, Min Woo Lee, Stephan Jaeger, Ryo Hisatsune, Alex Smalley and rising South African star Aldrich Potgieter.

Theegala balanced creativity with restraint in a round that had one bogey and three birdies and was among the better iron



players in the field.

For the first time in a men’s major, four players of Indian heritage — Theegala, Akshay Bhatia, Aaron Rai and Sudarshan Yellamaraju — are competing together in the same field.

Among them, Theegala, entered the week carrying perhaps the highest expectations. The California-born golfer of Telugu heritage has become one of the PGA Tour’s most popular personalities because of his fearless style and authenticity.

Since turning profession-

al in 2020, he has steadily matured into a genuine contender in elite events, highlighted by his breakthrough PGA Tour victory at the 2023 Fortinet Championship and several high other high finishes.

Theegala, who is sponsored by India’s Hero MotoCorp, said, “It’s a major championship. It’s been a while since I’ve been healthy for once, so it’s nice to get kicked around a lot. Like I said, tomorrow’s a new day. Who knows, it might kick me really bad.

LSG beat CSK by seven wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Mitchell Marsh's 38-ball 90 was a stunning rhapsody of power, carrying an already-eliminated Lucknow Super Giants to a seven-wicket win over Chennai Super Kings in an IPL match here on Friday.

Once the Super Kings posted a healthy 187 for five, which was built around Kartik Sharma's prudent 71, the Super Giants' task was cut out on a slightly two-paced track.

But Marsh, who along with his Australia teammate Josh Inglis (36, 31b) added 135 runs for the opening wicket to make a mockery of the pitch and even more so of some listless bowling by CSK.

Chennai stayed on 12 points from as many games, and now they need to win both their remaining matches and some other results to go their way to have a chance to enter the



play-offs.

There was some assistance to exploit on the deck, particularly if you dug the ball in, but the Chennai bowlers were more keen to discover

from non-existent swing while pitching the ball up.

On other occasions, the attempted snorters turned out to be pathetic half-trackers, but Marsh was not com-

plaining.

The 34-year-old gorged on the offerings in his inimitable style.

Pacer Anshul Kamboj felt the brute strength of 'Bison'

while getting pasted for four sixes in a row with a four to boot in the fifth over the chase. The over yielded 28 runs.

The LSG ended the Power Play with an impressive 86 without loss and Marsh continued to drive his side.

Pacer Spencer Johnson was his next target, hitting him for two fours and a six as the runs flowed in thick and fast.

Marsh reached his fifty off just 21 balls, and reaching a landmark only fuelled his desire to score even quicker.

But the smooth-sailing alliance was broken when Inglis skied Mukesh Choudhary to Urvil.

Marsh, who looked set for a second hundred of the season, departed in an unfortunate manner as Nicholas Pooran's straight drive crashed onto stumps at non-striker's end after taking a deflection from Choudhary's fingers.

Super Chess Classic: Praggnanandhaa draws with Alireza Firouzja in opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bucharest (Romania)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa survived a small scare before settling for a draw with Alireza Firouzja of France in the first round of the Super Chess Classics, the first Classical event of the Grand Chess Tour, here on Thursday.

It turned out to be an exciting affair after a dull Queen's gambit declined by Firouzja as black. As many as three minor pieces changed hands early and it looked like the game was headed towards a dull draw when Praggnanandhaa went for the complexities by allowing black to have connected passed pawns on the queen side in exchange for a strong center.

The Iranian-turned-French found some excellent resources in the middle game and was able to nearly rip apart the Indian's king



side but the position was so complicated that it was nearly impossible to find all the best moves for the human brain.

An error on move 35 led to a level rook and pawns endgame even though Praggnanandhaa was still a pawn less and the draw was a just result thereafter. The longest game of the day lasted 60 moves.

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France drew with Dutchman Anish Giri in the other keenly contested

game wherein the latter had a slight pull according to the machine. The Catalan opening as white did not yield much for the French GM and a few exchanges led to a dynamically balanced middle game. Giri might have had some chances but decided to play it safe and drew with repetition after 32 moves.

World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov could do little with his black pieces against Romanian Deac Bogdan-Daniel.

Pollard fined for using abusive language for fourth umpire



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dharamsala

Mumbai Indians'batting coach Kieron Pollard has been fined 15 percent of his applicable match fee for breaching the IPL's code of conduct by using abusive language for the fourth umpire.

The incident took place during MI's match against Punjab Kings here on Thursday night, in which the former emerged winners by six wickets in a last-ball thriller in the hill town.

"Kieron Pollard, Batting Coach, Mumbai Indians has been fined 15 per cent of his applicable match fee and accumulated one demerit point for breaching Level 1 of the IPL's Code of Conduct for Players and Team officials,"the IPL said in a press release issued on Friday morning.

"Pollard was found to have breached article 2.3 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which relates to 'use of an audible obscenity during a match'. "The incident occurred in the 19th over of the second innings when Pollard used abusive language towards the fourth umpire,"it said in the release.

Pollard admitted to the offence and accepted the sanction imposed by match referee, Pankaj Dharmani.

Pollard, the former big-hitting all-rounder form the West Indies and a longtime associate of MI, had been fined in the past, too, for breaching the IPL's code of conduct.

Fed Cup in Ranchi to serve as selection trial

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Federation Cup National Senior Athletics Competition, to be held from May 22 to 25 in Ranchi, will also serve as the selection trial for the upcoming inaugural edition of the Asian U23 Athletics Championships.

Athletes between the age of 20 to 22 as on December 31, 2026 are eligible for selection as per Asian Athletics Association guidelines, the national federation said. The continental meet will be held in Ordos, China from July 9 to 12. The Ranchi event is also important as it will be the last domestic track and field meet for the athletes to book tickets for the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, to be held from July 23 to August 2.

The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has announced the qualification standard for the the Asian U23 Athletics Championships. Most of the qualifying marks of the different events have been kept below the junior national records.

The AFI qualifying marks:
Men: 100m: 10.52 secs, **200m:** 21.30 secs, **400m:** 47.20 secs, **800m:** 1:49.00 secs, **1500m:** 3:49.00 secs, **5,000m:** 14:22.00 secs, **10,000m:** 30:00.00, **3000m steeplechase:** 8:58.00, **110mH:** 13.84 secs, **400m hurdle:** 50.29 secs, **high jump:** 2.12m, **pole vault:** 5.20m, **long jump:** 7.90m, **triple jump:** 16.00m,



shot put: 17.67m, **discus throw:** 54.00m, **hammer throw:** 60.00m, **javelin throw:** 74.00m, **decathlon:** 6905 points.

Women: 100m: 11.75 secs, **200m:** 23.84 secs, **400m:** 53.62 secs, **800m:** 2:11.00 secs, **1500m:** 4:20.00 secs, **5,000m:** 16:20.00 secs, **10,000m:** 35:00.00 secs, **3000m steeplechase:** 10:20.00 secs, **100m hurdles:** 13.73 secs, **400m hurdles:** 59.50 secs, **high jump:** 1.75m, **pole vault:** 4.00m, **long jump:** 6.30m, **triple jump:** 13.00m, **shot put:** 14.50m, **discus throw:** 50.73m, **hammer throw:** 55.00m, **javelin throw:** 50.00m, **heptathlon:** 5208 points.

We have not been able to handle pressure, admits PBKS assistant coach Brad Haddin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dharamsala

Punjab Kings assistant coach Brad Haddin admitted that his side has struggled to cope with pressure after it suffered a fifth successive defeat to continue a stunning mid-season slump in the ongoing Indian Premier League.

PBKS'latest loss came against Mumbai Indians, who emerged winners by six wickets in a last-ball thriller in the hill town on Thursday night.

It was a far cry from the seven-match unbeaten streak that PBKS enjoyed earlier in the season. The latest setback has left PBKS with a must-win scenario in their remaining two games to stay in playoff contention.

"We have just not been able to handle pressure in the last few defeats. We have not played our best cricket when we need to, which has been disappointing,"Haddin said in the post-match press conference.

"We are as disappointed as you guys are with the way we



started the tournament and where we are now. There is no hiding that we've got to play better."

PBKS appeared to be in control while defending 200 before an unbeaten 75 off 33 balls from Tilak Varma took MI home in the closing stages.

Reflecting on the defeat, Haddin said his side had done enough to stay ahead in the

Mumbai home,"he said.

PBKS'bowling has emerged as a major concern this season, with the side conceding runs at an economy rate of 10.77 — the worst among all teams — while also possessing the second-worst bowling average.

Despite the poor numbers, Haddin backed his bowling unit and pointed to the changing nature of T20 cricket, where totals once considered match-winning are no longer safe.

"What you do see in this tournament now is some unbelievable power. Two hundred used to be a really, really good score. And now it is a score that teams are not intimidated by. We have just got to find a way," he said.

Inconsistent KKR fight to stay alive as GT eye top-two finish

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Back home after nearly a month on the road and with their campaign hanging by a thread, Kolkata Knight Riders will look to stay alive in the IPL when they face a rampaging Gujarat Titans side chasing a top-two finish, here on Saturday.

It has been another inconsistent and underwhelming season for KKR under veteran Ajinkya Rahane, whose appointment as captain itself had raised questions after the franchise finished a disappointing eighth under him last year.

KKR had to wait till their seventh match (halfway stage) of the season to register their



first win and have looked far from a settled side throughout the campaign, with questionable team selections and batting-order hurting their rhythm.

Their brief revival, which brought four consecutive wins starting with the victory over Rajasthan Royals in their last home match on April 19, ended with a

defeat to Royal Challengers Bengaluru after sloppy fielding and a batting masterclass by Virat Kohli.

KKR now have three matches remaining and can reach a maximum of 15 points if they win all of them, but even that may not guarantee a playoff berth as qualification would then depend on other results.

Another defeat, however, would virtually end their campaign and could also intensify scrutiny on Rahane's future with the franchise.

Their four-match winning run was built largely around the return to form of spin twins Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravarthy, along with consistent contributions from vice-captain Rinku Singh.

Shastri backs Samson for future India T20I captaincy



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India's T20 World Cup title-winning star Sanju Samson would be a strong contender for national team captaincy in the shortest format in the next two-three years, says former head coach Ravi Shastri.

Suryakumar Yadav led India to the ICC Men's T20 World Cup title at home two months ago, where the 31-year-old Samson was named Player of the Tournament.

Shastri said India may have to look beyond Suryakumar by the time the next T20 World Cup comes around in 2028, when the current skipper will be 37.

"India, come the next (T20) World Cup (in 2028), might be looking for a new captain, depending on how Surya goes over the next couple of years,"Shastri was quoted as saying by 'The ICC Review'.

But Sanju Samson has put himself there for a leadership role because he's done that in the past for Rajasthan (Royals).

Approach remaining games with more fearless attitude, Boucher tells PBKS



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dharamsala

Former South Africa wicketkeeper-batter Mark Boucher believes a mental reset and adopting a fearless approach in the remaining matches could help Punjab Kings rediscover momentum heading into the business end of the IPL.

PBKS lost their fifth straight game in the ongoing season here on Thursday, going down to Mumbai Indians by six wickets.

Speaking on JioHotstar's 'Google



Search AI Mode Match Centre Live', Boucher said, "Punjab Kings have found themselves in a difficult position after a series of close defeats, especially considering the strong start they had to the season."

"Sometimes, constantly thinking about the top four and qualification scenarios can add extra pressure, and

perhaps stepping away from that mindset could actually help them."

He added that adopting a fearless approach would also help the side.

"If they approach the remaining games with a more fearless attitude and feel like they have nothing to lose, it might free them up mentally,"Boucher said.

Hardik expected to be back for KKR game: Shardul Thakur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dharamsala

Mumbai Indians all-rounder Shardul Thakur clarified that skipper Hardik Pandya's absence in the last three matches was due to injury, adding that he could return for their next game against Kolkata Knight Riders while dismissing speculation over the star's future with the franchise.

Pandya did not travel to Dharamsala for MI's six-wicket win over Punjab Kings, where Jasprit Bumrah became the team's third captain this season after Suryakumar Yadav also missed the game following the birth of his child.

"Hardik is injured, so he couldn't travel for a couple of games," Thakur said at the post-match media interaction on Thursday.

Down with back spasm, Pandya first missed MI's



home game against Lucknow Super Giants on May 4 and then sat out the clash against Royal Challengers Bengaluru in Raipur despite travelling with the squad.

"He went to Raipur (for the RCB match on May 10), but couldn't play. He is training in Mumbai now and I expect him to be back in Kolkata and play (at Eden Gardens on May 20). Players like them, we always miss the quality," Thakur added.

IPL digital viewership up, TV set to hit 500M: Official broadcaster

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The watch-time of the ongoing Indian Premier League has increased by seven per cent in the digital space, while the TV viewership is on course to hit the 500 million mark, according to the event's broadcasters.

The overall digital reach of the IPL has grown by 15 per cent, 'JioStar'stated in a press release.

The data is for 51 matches on Linear TV, and 57 games on the digital platform.



"CTV has seen a 25 per cent growth in reach with watch-time up by 20 per cent. The regional language watch-time has seen a staggering uptick of 42 per cent,"the company claimed.